曲香蒙求
Light to the Tavern

目录 / Contents

三与九 / The Third and the Ninth 2
百样事 / What the Xiangruis Do 8
闲时节 / Idle Time 15
存身之处 / A Place to Belong 24
去岁如山 / Time Slipping Away 31
结新彩 / Festoons 37
行路难 / Difficult Is the Way 44
且尽余杯 / Till the Last Drop 50

三与九
The Third and the Ninth CH16601-01

Street, Inside the City
城中街上

The main street of Pèi City bustles with activity. Crowds throng the thoroughfare, the cries of vendors ring out, silks drape high over the streets, and piles of red pomegranates and walnuts rise in little towers on the market stalls.
沛城的正街最是热闹，人头攒动，摊贩吆喝声不绝于耳，绸缎悬街而过，红石榴和胡桃累成小塔。

A vendor pulls some freshly baked sesame buns out of the earthen oven behind him and lays them in a steaming stack on the stall counter. They exude an aromatic fragrance.
麻饼在土坑里焙出喷香的滋味，冒着热气一摞儿摆在摊位上，芝麻落了一桌。

The little girl is huddled in front of the stall, her head barely peeking above the tabletop, her eyes unblinking, transfixed by the sesame buns.
这会儿，一个小人儿凑在饼摊前，脑袋将将比桌面高不了多少，一双眼盯着胡饼挪不开半分。

Child Beggar: Aaahh, give me ...
乞儿：啊，啊，这——

Jiu: The little girl points into her open mouth with her finger.
小九：小人儿用手指着自己微张的嘴。

Child Beggar: Feeling hungry ...
乞儿：我要吃饼，肚子饿了……

Citizen V: No money, no food. I'm running a business here. Now go away, shoo!
城中居民 V：没钱就没有饼吃，你这小乞儿晃了几天了，别挡着我生意，去去去～

The little one, not understanding a word, casually snatches up a bun and devours it.
小人儿听不懂这些，随手抓了一只饼，就大口嚼起来。

In recent days, the entire merchant hub has come to know this little beggar, whose origins remain unknown, as she wanders the streets all day and night.
这几日，整个金市的人都认识这个不知从何而来的小乞儿，整日在街上游荡。

Citizen V: Hey, beggar kid, give that back! You've been stealing buns from me for days!
城中居民 V：你这颠乞儿，给我还过来，连着这多些日子，吃了我多少饼了。

Although the little one does not understand the purpose of these words, she can still sense the building rage behind them. She turns tail and flees, but before she can take more than a step, she collides head-on with two figures. The larger one catches her wrist.
小人儿旁的不懂，生气还是能看出来的，于是转身就跑。却不料迎面正撞上两道身影，被其中威武非凡的那个一把擒住了手腕。

Facao: Where are you going?
法曹：往哪儿跑？小乞儿。

Facao: I've heard endless complaints about your stealing. You're not getting away.
法曹：早听说了你，真是择日不如撞日，正巧落在我手里。

Facao: Not this time. I'll get you locked away in prison. Then you'll never steal again!
法曹：你可不能再跑了，这次拘了投在监中，看你还怎么捣乱！

Lizheng: I wouldn't have expected the Fǎcáo to deal with little girls ... I assume she committed a felony?
里正：一个小娘子也让法曹这么兴师动众，看来犯的是重罪。

Facao: What you don't know, sir, is that this little beggar has been wandering the streets for days. No one knows where she came from. When she's thirsty, she drinks from the horse troughs, and when she's hungry, she steals food from the vendors.
法曹：您有所不知，这颠乞儿不知从何而来，整日在街上晃荡，渴了就去饮马的槽里喝一捧，饿了就抢铺子里的东西吃。

Facao: She's quick as a stallion, too. No one could catch her when she entered the city. The patroller informed me a few days ago.
法曹：她腿脚又快，像个急驹，都拿她不住。早些日子，巡城的已跟我上报过了。

The little girl struggles, attempting to break free from the large hand that grips her.
小人儿不断推搡着那只大手，企图挣脱。

Lǐzhèng leans down to scrutinize the young offender.
里正不紧不慢地俯下身子，仔细端详年幼的犯人。

Lizheng: What's your name? Have you ever been to school ...? No, can you talk?
里正：你姓甚名谁？可曾开蒙……不，会言语吗？

Child Beggar: I ... I need to stay in the city. The city needs a Xiángruì.
乞儿：我、我……要留在城里，城里需要祥瑞。

Lizheng: She can talk. Perhaps she's from a decent family, and something happened to them. Isn't it too harsh to put a little girl who has suffered so much into prison? Let's not make a fuss of it.
里正：她会言语，许是家道中落，不知遭了什么难才成这样，就此拘回去，会不会太过小题大做，于民所不善？

Facao: ...
法曹：……

Facao: Actually, I was thinking that prison would provide her with food and shelter. In the meantime, I could work on locating her parents.
法曹：我本是想着监中管饭，也有个屋棚遮风，到时候再细细帮她问问家人所在。

Lizheng: My apologies. I suppose you are considerate under that harsh exterior of yours.
里正：你是个毛髯胡子，雷公似的人，难得也有这份细心。

Lǐzhèng straightens up and strokes his beard. He appears to have already devised a plan for the beggar child's fate.
里正直起身，捋一捋胡子，心中已对这乞儿的去处有了安排。

Yard, Tavern
酒坊院中

After making their way down several streets, the three of them arrive at a tavern.
行过几条街，几人便至一处酒坊。

It is filled with patrons. Amidst the clinking of cups and the raising of toasts, idle chatter and laughter abound, creating a scene of merriment.
坊厅内早已坐了不少酒客，推杯换盏间，闲言欢语不止，一派欢闹景象。

As they enter, the scent of liquor hits their nostrils. A graceful figure moves swiftly among the clientele, her presence as striking as it is efficient.
刚入门便觉曲香扑鼻，一个俏丽人影穿梭在众酒客间，麻利又干练。

???: Welcome, Lǐzhèng, Fǎcáo! What brings you here?
???：两位里面请，难得里正光顾我这小地方，呦，法曹也在呢。

???: Take a seat! You came just at the right time. I have some jars of Melon Brew that I haven't opened yet. I'm thinking that a couple of distinguished guests can do me a favor and have the first cup.
???: 快快落座，我这坊里刚来了几坛上好的瓜瓢青，还没开封，正想着哪个贵人来帮着启封呢。

Citizen IV: Ms. Xǔ, you slippery little thing! If Lǐzhèng hadn't come today, when would you have told us about these new arrivals?
城中居民 IV：许娘子好生狡猾，有好酒都藏着，只等我们里正来才提一口。

Citizen IV: Poor us, not even qualified to smell it!
城中居民 IV：我们呐，只跟着听个名儿，可怜哦可怜哦～

Ms. Xǔ feigns annoyance, playfully scolding her patrons with a smile. They burst into laughter. As this moment passes, one patron stands to invite the two officials to take a seat.
许娘子佯作嗔怒，笑骂了两句，酒客们也是哄作一团。此间过了，便有人起身请两位落座。

Facao: No need. We're not here to drink.
法曹：不必了，我们今日不是来喝酒的。

Ms. Xu: You're not? Oh ... Well, everything's above board here. I've never even watered down a drink. Just ask my guests, they'll tell you!
许娘子：那……我这小酒坊一向秉公守法，酒中也未曾掺过水，不信可以问问坊厅内的这些人。

Lizheng: Heh heh, don't worry, Ms. Xǔ. We're just here to check up on the stores.
里正：哈哈，你却是误会了，此次不是兴师问罪，只是来看看坊间民情。

Lizheng: Is everything going well with your tavern?
里正：许娘子，最近生意可好?

Ms. Xu: Yes, everything's fine. Some drinkers can get really talky, but that's all. No troublemakers, thanks to your management.
许娘子：托您的福，近来这些酒蒙子都还安生，几杯下肚就歪了，只有说胡话的，没有闹事的。

Ms. Xu: You know, most days, I have plenty of time to make the rice buns that I sell to the locals ...
许娘子：平日里倒也轻松，做些饼子来卖，街坊也总光顾。

Ms. Xu: But on liquor permit days, there are so many patrons in the tavern, and I have to serve all of them myself.
许娘子：只是放酒日有些忙不过来，又要备酒盛酒，又要招待客人。

Lizheng: What a coincidence! I have just found you a helper.
里正：正好，我刚给你找见了一个帮手。

Fǎcáo steps aside. He is about to introduce the child to Ms. Xǔ when he turns around to find that the little beggar has disappeared without a trace.
法曹听言便挪开身形，刚要向酒坊老板娘介绍一番，一转身却不见了那乞儿的踪影。

Facao: She was here just now! Where did she go?
法曹：怎么的，这小娘子不知又跑哪里去了?

After a thorough search, they find her curled up behind the counter. She refuses to answer any of their questions.
众人四处查看了好一阵儿，才在柜台后找到那娇小的身影，彼时正窝在地上，问什么也不答。

Ms. Xu: Lǐzhèng, don't tell me this is the new helper you were talking about.
许娘子：里正，你说的帮手莫不是这个小乞儿?

Lizheng: Oh right, exactly.
里正：不错，正是她。

Ms. Xu: There's no way I can take her. She looks more like a wild beast than a child, and she can't even speak fluently. She seems totally uncivilized! How could a girl like this help me?
许娘子： 呵，看她行为乖张，模样缺了教化。目不灵光，嘴不利索，哪有能帮我半分的样子。

Ms. Xu: Honestly. If she stays here, I'll have to spend just as much time taking care of her as I do the tavern! Lǐzhèng, you better not throw this hot potato to me.
许娘子： 她要是来了这里，我倒是要匀出九分气力照顾她呢。里正还是莫要把这烫手的山芋扔给我了。

Lizheng: You're right. She needs to be civilized. That's why I brought her here. Everyone in the city knows you're sharp as a tack. Why, you could teach a monkey to talk if you had to!
里正： 她的确是缺少教化，所以正好在此学学。坊间都知道你许三娘子是个伶俐聪慧的人儿，就算是山上的猢狲跟你呆几日，都能学个一两分灵巧。

Lizheng: Besides, you're a kind person. No one is more suited to take care of a little girl than you.
里正： 况且，你待人又宽善，把她交给你，我们也放心。

Facao: We have no clue where we might find her parents. We can't just let her wander the streets.
法曹： 这小小娘子寻亲却半点消息也无，现下是无亲无故，不好放着街上乱跑。

Ms. Xu: What about the charity hall? I'm running a tavern here, not a school! Besides, she hasn't spoken a word since she got here! Is she some sort of dumb?
许娘子： 善堂怎么说，难道收不得人了？我这儿是个酒坊，可不是什么学堂，看她这样子连话也不会说，是不是哑巴哦?

Upon hearing the word "dumb," the beggar girl stands up and dusts off her sleeves. She looks around the room, finally resting her gaze upon Ms. Xǔ.
听到哑巴一词，这乞儿竟主动站起身来，拍拍衣袖。她环视一圈，最后把目光落在许娘子身上。

Child Beggar: I'm not "dumb." My mommy called me Jiǔ.
乞儿： 我不是哑巴，我阿娘叫我小九。

Lizheng: Jiǔ. Does that mean you're the ninth in your family? Well, it's easy to remember.
里正： “小九”，可是在家中行九之意？倒也朗朗上口。

Lizheng: See? She didn't say a word to us the whole way here, but she's already talking to you.
里正： 你瞧，原先她跟我们一路，连名字也不说，到你这里却讲了，也是有缘。

Ms. Xu: Three and nine ... What kind of fate could this be, if not a twisted one?
许娘子： 三与九，什么缘分，怕不是孽缘。

Somehow, the pure gaze and innocent, carefree demeanor of this little beggar makes her difficult to shoo away. Eventually, Ms. Xǔ's tone softens.
不知怎么的，跟前这小乞儿眼光纯粹，又透出天真烂漫姿态，让人不忍驱赶，许娘子的话头最终还是软了下来。

Ms. Xu: ... Jiǔ, huh? You've been begging for days, yet you still had the energy to run and hide in the tavern. You must be healthy.
许娘子： ……这小九娘子，模样倒也还周正，猴子般溜来溜去，精神头足，瞧上去没什么病。

Facao: She's quite the runner. Many adults couldn't keep up with her. Maybe she can help you run errands.
法曹： 对，她腿脚很是利索，在街上几个人都拿不住她，帮你做些跑堂拿物的事，定不在话下。

Ms. Xu: But, you see ... the extra food and clothing ...
许娘子： 只是这吃穿用度……多一个人就要多上一份。

Ms. Xu: I can barely earn enough money to feed myself.
许娘子： 我这酒坊的收入原先也只是将将度日。

Lǐzhèng wastes no time in instructing Fǎcáo to produce the settlement fee and hand it over to Ms. Xǔ.
里正也不耽搁，让法曹拿出早已备好的安置费，交予老板娘。

The patrons gather, eager to see the amount, but Ms. Xǔ waves them off with a flick of her wrist. They laugh among themselves and return to downing their drinks.
酒客们嘻嘻哈哈凑在一起想看看有多少，都被许娘子扬手打了开去。不过他们也不恼，以此为由头又喝下几杯。

Ms. Xu: Hmm ... This could be enough for now. But kids grow so fast, you know? I'll have to get her new clothes, new shoes every now and then ...
许娘子：嗯……这算是能解燃眉之需，不过她年纪又小，又要添置不少衣裳，往后的用度想必是越来越……

Lizheng: Haha! I've heard many rumors of Xǔ's silver tongue. You surely don't disappoint.
里正：哈哈，我常听说许娘子口嘴伶俐，善讨价还价，今日也是见着了。

Lizheng: Alright, you've just won yourself the position of supplier to the Zhící. You'll be responsible for the ceremonial liquors during festivals.
里正：也罢，往后但凡大小节，职祠里要用到的礼酒都交由你这里供吧。

Ms. Xu: Thank you so much, Lǐzhèng. I'll make the best liquor for the ceremonies.
许娘子：多谢里正，这礼酒肯定千万分上心。

Ms. Xu: And of course, I'll take good care of her.
许娘子：这小九在酒坊里，我也肯定好好管教她。

With matters concluded, Lǐzhèng and Fǎcáo do not linger any longer. There are still many tasks awaiting them in the city, and so they take their leave.
事已毕，里正与法曹也不做过多停留。城里等他们要办的事还多，两人就此告辞。

The tavern quickly regains its earlier liveliness. On this precious liquor permit day, not a single moment must be wasted. Ms. Xǔ is still adjusting to the sudden arrival of her unexpected helper.
酒坊里又恢复了之前的欢闹，在放酒日，每个时辰都不能浪费。许娘子这边还有点没适应，才这一会儿就多了个帮手。

Ms. Xu: Follow me. You'll be staying in the tavern from now on. Starting tomorrow, you'll help me run the business. If you need anything, just tell me. Oh, and don't steal from others again.
许娘子：来吧，今天开始你就是酒坊里的人了，要什么都跟我说，可不能像之前在街上一样随手拿。

Jiu: Water. I'm thirsty.
小九：渴，我渴了。

Ms. Xu: Water's in the yard. I'll get it for you.
许娘子：水缸在院中，我去给你打一碗来喝。

Two officials walk down the street, their pace leisurely as they converse about the events of the day.
官府两人走在街上，却是不紧不忙地聊着今日之事。

Facao: Lǐzhèng, why did you do all that to help that beggar girl?
法曹：里正今日为何大费周章，专为那乞儿安置好去处?

Lizheng: When I first looked at that girl, I had the feeling that I'd seen her before. Besides, it would be a pity to have such a bright young thing roaming the streets.
里正：我只是觉得这孩子面目可亲，像是在哪里见过。况且她眉目聪慧，流落街头太过可惜，需要个人来教导。

Fǎcáo nods, habitually pressing down on the short sword at his waist and casting a final glance back at the tavern before turning into a side street.
法曹闻言点头，习惯性压了下腰间的短剑，在转入侧街前最后回看了一眼酒坊。

Facao: I see.
法曹： 如此甚好。

Ms. Xu: You'll sleep here tonight. It used to be a utility room, but I've cleaned it, and the bed's new.
许娘子： 今晚你就睡这里，虽是杂房，可床铺都是半新的，平日里也没人睡过。

Ms. Xu: I heard that you slept on the street, so I guess you're not afraid of the dark.
许娘子： 听说你之前都是睡在街上的，想必是不怕黑的，这油灯我就不给你放了。

Ms. Xu: I sleep in the room next to yours. Call me if you need anything.
许娘子： 夜里有什么事就喊我，我在廊下第一间。

Jiu: Yes. Sleep when you're sleepy.
小九： 嗯，嗯，累了就睡觉。

Jiǔ rests her hands by her ear, tilts her head, and feigns the sound of slumber.
小九边说边把手放在耳边，歪着脑袋，做出酣睡的模样。

The child's innocent and carefree spirit softens Ms. Xǔ's heart, prompting her to leave a few tender instructions before departing.
这孩童才有的天真烂漫，让许娘子心中一软，嘱咐几句便离开了。

Jiu: I'm alone now. Don't sleep on the street anymore.
小九： 只有小九一个人了，今天不住在大大的路上。

Yielding to the moment, the child lies on the floor of the room. Tonight, there are no twinkling stars to accompany her, no cool breeze to caress her, only the faintly discernible beams overhead.
小孩子顺势躺在房间的地上，今夜没有闪闪的星星陪伴她，也没有凉风，只有黑漆漆的、隐隐约约的房梁。

Wooden Doll: With a rustling sound, a troop of wooden dolls materializes out of thin air. They frolick and cavort on the bed, the ground, and on Jiǔ's clothes.
木头人： 随着一阵窸窸窣窣声，一群木头做的小人儿凭空出现，在床铺上，在地上，甚至在小九的衣服上跳跃嬉闹。

Wooden Dolls: ***chuckles* New place! Fun!**
木头小人群： 嘻嘻嘻——新地方——真好玩！

Wooden Dolls: Liquor jars, liquor jars! Customers raising their cups!
木头小人群： 酒坛子——酒缸子——香味扑鼻——周客起——

The wooden dolls turn the day's sights into lyrical verses in an endless song.
木头小人们把白天的所见变作唱词，唱个不停。

One doll pushes through the others, leaping down from the bed to whisper into Jiǔ's ear.
其中一个拨开其他木头小人，从床铺跳到小九耳边。

Wooden Dolls: Personal feelings. You're having a lot.
木头小人： 私情，你动了许多。

Jiu: They're not personal feelings. You don't know anything.
小九： 这不是私情，你又在瞎说了。

Wooden Dolls: Don't forget what the Daoist said.
木头小人： 别忘了，道士的话。

Jiu: You're annoying. I'm sleeping now.
小九： 别闹，你真烦，我要睡了。

Jiu: I need to run a business tomorrow. Do you even know what "business" means?
小九： 明天还要上工，你知道上工是什么意思吗?

Wooden Dolls: No.
木头小人： 没听过，不知道。

Jiu: Me neither. Maybe it means ... um ... I'll figure it out tomorrow.
小九： 我也不知道，好像是……好像是……反正明天就知道了。

6#1
6#1

百样事
What the Xiangruis Do CH16601-02

As the sun begins to rise, so too does the sound of clanging and clattering—a cacophony of pots and pans crescendos, accompanied by the clinking of liquor jars being shuffled about.
日上竿头，房外早响起丁零当啷声，无非是锅碗瓢盆之乱，其中夹杂着酒坛碰挪之响。

Suddenly, the door is thrust open.
突然，房门被一把推开。

Ms. Xu: Rise and shine, girl! It's the liquor permit day. Guests are coming. It's going to be a long day. If only they would go to work as early as they come to the tavern ...
许娘子： 快点起身，放酒日最是忙了，那些酒蒙子自家干活儿天天喊累，喝酒倒是要赶头筹——

Ms. Xu: Huh? Why are you sleeping on the floor?
许娘子： 咦，你怎的睡在地上?

Ms. Xu: Did you fall down in your sleep? Get up, come on, don't get cold.
许娘子： 这是夜里翻下床了还是……一晚上睡地上千万别受了凉气，快，快起来。

Jiu: Don't wanna wake up ...
小九： 唔……肚子不饿，不起来……

Jiu: Sleep is good ...
小九： 睡觉更舒服……

Ms. Xu: What a lazy girl! No work, no food. You're not going to steal from me like you did from those vendors on the street.
许娘子： 真是缘悭教化，散漫惯了。不做事就没饭吃，这里可不是大街上。

Ms. Xu: I'll get you to work!
许娘子： 看我怎么治你。

Ms. Xǔ swiftly lifts the sluggard from the ground, dusts off the dirt from her body, wipes her face, and pushes her out the door.
许娘子一个提溜就把地上的懒虫拽起来，同她拍掉身上的灰，抹一把脸就推出去。

It seems that, for the first time in years, Jiǔ is not allowed to wake up on her own accord.
这似乎是多年以来，小九第一次没有睡到自然醒。

Ms. Xu: In the tavern, our business is to sell people liquor and earn money.
许娘子： 酒坊，酒坊，讲究的就是一个酒。

Ms. Xu: To work here, you'll need to be able to recognize all the liquors. Whatever the customer orders, we serve them.
许娘子： 认识酒水是酒坊里的第一等条件，酒客要什么酒，就拿什么酒。

Ms. Xu: Every patron, rich or poor, has their own preferences. It is only through matching those preferences that you make money in this business. A wealthy man won't always want the most expensive wine, and a poor man won't always want the cheapest.
许娘子：要是好酒落了没钱的主嘴里，亏的是我们，要是坏酒入了有钱的主嘴里，亏的还是我们。

Ms. Xu: Your first task is to memorize all the names of the different liquors.
许娘子：你今天上工就先把酒认全了。

Jiu: I don't want to do business. Too sleepy.
小九：上工不好，眼皮打不开。

Jiu: And I don't want to remember anything. The street is better. I just take whatever I want.
小九：还要记各种东西，在街上比较好，可以拿饼吃。

Ms. Xu: Taking things without permission is called stealing. That's what thieves do.
许娘子：随便拿别人的饼，谓之窃，只有野东西才会不拿钱去换东西吃。

Ms. Xu: Listen, here in my tavern, you need to work to get food. Otherwise, I'll only give you water.
许娘子：听好了，在我这里吃东西要拿劳力来换，不上工就只能喝水。水管够。

Ms. Xu: Sweetie, every living person needs a certain job to make a living.
许娘子：普天之下，是人就要谋一份活计，做一个行当。

Ms. Xu: Yes, you'll be tired—exhausted even—but through work, you can earn the food you need.
许娘子：虽然做得遍体疲乏，但是不偷不抢，每日也总有一口稳饭吃。

Ms. Xu: Do you understand, Jiǔ?
许娘子：我说这些，你到底听懂了没有，小九?

Jiu: Hmm ... I guess.
小九：唔……我大约是知道了。

Jiu: Work for food, or go hungry.
小九：做工就有饼吃，不做工就饿肚子。

This straightforward explanation leaves no room for debate. Ms. Xǔ feels satisfied that she has corrected the girl's beggar-like behavior by a fraction or two.
这直白的理解让人挑不出毛病，许娘子心生满意，算是把这姑娘乞儿般的行径改去了一两分。

Ms. Xǔ then leads Jiǔ to the front hall of the tavern.
随后，她便领着小九到酒坊前厅。

As the sun rises higher, the streets become busier. Several early patrons have already arrived at the tavern and are now peering in from the entrance.
这会儿日渐升起，街上人也多起来，酒坊中早已来了三五好酒之客，在门口张望着。

Ms. Xǔ quickly ushers them to their seats and ladles out their liquor, serving them according to their respective preferences. Once they settle in, Ms. Xǔ takes Jiǔ aside for more detailed instruction.
许娘子见此赶紧招呼落座，又依照各人喜好，舀了酒端上。等忙完了，许娘子才拉着小九，细细教导。

Ms. Xu: Different liquors taste different and have different costs.
许娘子：任何酒坊里的酒水都分三六九等，价钱也是三六九等。

Ms. Xu: There are three aspects through which you can tell liquors apart: transparency, scent, and taste.
许娘子：识酒可是个大学问，酒要识颜色，闻香气，品味道。

Ms. Xu: A good liquor should be transparent, have a mellow aroma, and have a long-lasting aftertaste.
许娘子：好的酒水，要颜色清透，香味醇厚，品起来回味无穷，引得人流连忘返。

Ms. Xu: That's what the customers are after.
许娘子：拴住客人就靠的是这几样东西。

Accompanied by Jiǔ, Ms. Xǔ saunters past the liquor cabinet, where rows of liquor jars stand like a troop of portly warriors, awaiting the general's inspection.
许娘子带着小九在酒柜边走了一圈，排排酒坛，像一群大腹便便的威猛武将，正等着将军的检校。

The vermilion paper jackets on the jars present their whimsical nicknames, each more amusing than the last, while wafts of fragrant spirits drift from their rims.
坛上的朱纸写着各自的诨名儿，一个顶一个有趣，阵阵杜康芬香从坛沿漫出。

However, Jiǔ does not recognize the characters. Instead, she memorizes the brush strokes as if they were the components of a painting.
不过小九并不识得字，只把那些草书的名字当作图画片儿来记。

Jiu: They smell better than flowers, and each one has a different scent!
小九：闻起来比山上的花还香，每个都不一样。

Ms. Xu: Of course they do. Every liquor has its own unique fragrance.
许娘子：当然不一样了，百酒百香。

Ms. Xu: Now, look at these jars. This is Fushui; the one next to it is Earth Spring; the one above is West Fair; and here is the best seller: Great Mister ...
许娘子：来，记住，这一坛是富水，旁边的是土窟春，再边上一坛是西市腔，排头的一坛是郎官清，店里卖得最好的……

Ms. Xu: This is the Sanle liquor. My ancestors learned the recipe from Persian merchants. It's made of multiple fruits and helps work up your appetite and digest food ...
许娘子：还有这三勒浆，是前人从波斯商人那里学来的酿法，这酒以多种果子合酿，能解暑祛瘟，健脾消食。

Ms. Xu: Do you remember all that? Repeat what I just said.
许娘子：记住了没，小九？你跟着报一遍名儿。

Jiǔ counts on her fingers, carefully recalling each detail.
小九掰着手指头细细回想着。

Jiu: Um ... Dirty Things, West Hair, Crazy Sir ...
小九：呃……土窟窿，西边墙，狼官儿……

Jiu: Sunny liquor ... helps workout ...
小九：果子酿，健脾消食……

Jiǔ's words draw laughter from the patrons, who have been keenly listening to this recent round of instruction.
小九这番话引得众酒客都笑起来，刚才那一通教学，众人都在竖着耳朵听呢。

Old Drinker: Hahaha, what an interesting errand girl!
酒翁：哈哈哈，你这小跑堂真是个有趣的小人儿。

Old Drinker: I think her names are even better than yours!
酒翁：她这新说的名字，比原来的还好听。

Ms. Xu: Mr. Shěn, don't make fun of her.
许娘子：沈阿翁，你可别取笑了。

Ms. Xu: What was that? She didn't recount a single word correctly!
许娘子：这说的是什么一串词，前前后后一个都没记住。

Ms. Xu: That I would surrender to Lǐzhèng so easily! In so few words, he convinced me to commit this act of charity. And he said I was the one with the silver tongue!
许娘子：我也是心软，平日里原是个不吃亏的人，昨天被里正用那三两句就糊弄住了，得了这么个主儿。

Old Drinker: Hahaha, who knew that kind Ms. Xǔ could get so frustrated!
酒翁：哈哈哈，许娘子平日里，明明待谁都和气模样，对我们这些老酒虫从不说一句重话。

Old Drinker: You sound like a stubborn old teacher!
酒翁：今天一板一眼起来，倒像个老学究了。

Ms. Xu: Not sure about the stubborn and old part, but yes, I'll have to become at least a half-teacher.
许娘子：这话说得不错，从今日起，恐怕我真是要当上半个教书先生了。

Ms. Xu: This is the little girl Lǐzhèng brought here. Her name is Jiǔ. Though she lacks social skills, she seems pretty smart.
许娘子：喏，这就是昨天里正送来的小小娘子，名唤小九。我是三娘子，她也排个九娘子。虽然礼教一概不懂，不过看起来还挺聪明。

Jiu: The Daoist said smart is good.
小九：聪明是好事，道士跟我说过。

Old Drinker: You're being too harsh on her, Ms. Xǔ. It's not Jiǔ's fault. The names are hard to remember.
酒翁：许娘子，你就是太严格了，要我说这小九一点也不笨，瞧瞧，那些酒名多难记。

Old Drinker: You should teach her little by little, like how we start drinking liquor from a small cup, then move on to a bowl.
酒翁：做事还是要从小事做起，喝酒也要从小杯喝起嘛。

Old Drinker: Let her start with serving the liquor. Come, Jiǔ, give me a bowl of Earth Spring.
酒翁：就从端酒做起就行了，来，九娘子，给我这老酒虫端上一碗土窟春。

Ms. Xu: It's her first day; she won't know which is which. I'll get it.
许娘子：噫，她第一天上工，哪学得会这些，还是我来给你倒吧。

Before she can move, Jiǔ dashes to the liquor cabinet. She peers left and right, fiercely sniffing the air, determined to pinpoint which jar contains Earth Spring.
不过小九却三两步跑到酒柜旁，左瞧右看，又用鼻子狠命在空气中嗅探，想要找出“土窟窿”是哪一坛。

Ms. Xǔ jumps on this opportunity, signaling with her eyes for Jiǔ to fetch the third jar on the first row.
一旁的许娘子顺水推舟，使个眼色，让她拿来了排头第三的那一坛。

Old Drinker: See, she did it! Told you she could handle it. Maybe she'll even replace you in a couple of years!
酒翁：看，她多熟练，我说了是个聪慧的小人儿，过两年老板娘的位置可能就是她来当喽。

Ms. Xu: Heh heh, I couldn't ask for more! She'll do all the work, and I'll just sit back and enjoy my life. Not to mention that I won't have to deal with the mess you leave behind anymore.
许娘子：咯咯咯～那是最好了，我正好当个甩手掌柜，日日坐在后面享清福，也不用天天对着你们这一坊酒蒙子。

Upon opening the jar of Earth Spring, a unique fragrance bursts forth. The Pèilín River winds around Pèi City, and it is from the river's upper reaches that Ms. Xǔ draws her water, for only this crisp and clear liquid can brew such a uniquely fragrant liquor.
那坛土窟春一打开，便涌出股奇香。沛霖川绕着沛城而过，许娘子每每取这条河上游的水，只有这清冽的水才能酿出这奇香的酒。

Old Drinker is imagining the liquor from the jar filling his porcelain bowl in a steady stream. But the young girl before him plunges her hands into the jar, scoops up a handful of the crisp, exquisite liquor, and presents it to him, cupped in her hands.
老酒客正想象这坛中酒成线，盛满自己的瓷碗，但接着就看见那小娘子将两手伸入酒坛中，掬起一捧清冽美酒送至他跟前。

Jiu: Drink, sir!
小九：客人喝酒～

Jiu: Drink please!
小九：喝酒～请喝酒～

Before she can finish speaking, the Earth Spring liquor has already slipped through her fingers, drenching the patron's lapel.
话还未说完，土窟春已顺着她的指缝流个精光，酒客的衣襟也被淋了个酒味扑鼻，香满身。

The tavern's patrons are at first taken aback, then they burst into hearty laughter. These guests love liquor—they cherish it dearly—but what they love even more is the atmosphere that comes with drinking it.
坊内众人先是一愣，随即哄笑一堂。酒客爱酒，惜酒，但更爱喝酒时的活泛气氛。

For these patrons, when they are enjoying liquor, all things are filled with joy.
酒到酣时，诸事皆乐。

Ms. Xu: Hahaha, sorry about this one-of-a-kind "Palm Drink." It's her first day here; please give her some patience.
许娘子：咯咯咯～莫怪罪，莫怪罪，这碗天下独一份的手心酿，是小九第一天上工，单请你一个人喝的。

Ms. Xu: Have two more bowls of West Fair. On the house!
许娘子：我先给你赔不是了，今日请你两大碗西市腔，管保你晕着头回去。

Ms. Xu: I would give you the Earth Spring, but she put her hands into it, so I'm afraid the flavor has been altered.
许娘子：只是这一坛上好的土窟春，被这小九一伸手，经了肉气，怕是要发酸变味儿，不能喝了。

Despite these apologies, Ms. Xǔ does not blame the girl. Instead, she examines her small hands over and over, fearing the strong liquor might have burned her skin. She then fetches a cloth to clean up the spilled liquor on the table.
话是这样说，许娘子却并不怪罪，只是把她一双小手拉来看了又看，怕那烈酒烧了那肌肤，又去拿了巾子来收拾这满桌的美酒。

Old Drinker is not annoyed in the slightest. Having gained two large bowls of West Fair for free, he is naturally delighted and moves to another table to continue drinking.
老酒虫自然是不恼的，他白得了两大碗西市腔，自然乐在其中，换了张桌子又继续喝起来。

Jiu: Weird. He didn't get angry; he just kept drinking.
小九：多奇怪，大家不急也不恼，都接着喝起酒。

Jiu: What does liquor taste like?
小九：酒……到底是什么味儿呢?

Ms. Xu: It tastes ... complicated. It can bring people joy, but also great sorrow.
许娘子：酒呢，是世间上独一份的惬意，也是独一份的糊涂。

Ms. Xu: I'll leave it to you to find out, but only after you grow up.
许娘子：不过到底是什么味儿，还得等你再长些年头，自己来尝尝了。

Hearing this, Jiǔ immediately dips her finger into the puddle of liquor on the table, intending to taste it.
听此，小九立刻就用手指沾了些桌上还未挥发干的酒液，要送入嘴里。

Fortunately, Ms. Xǔ intercepts her.
还好许娘子眼疾手快地拦下了她。

Ms. Xu: Hey, wait! I just said, "After you grow up!" Don't be so hasty, little lady!
许娘子：哎，哎——！我说的可是“再长些年头”……你身板尚小，年岁不大，动起手来却不含糊，倒真利利索索的。

Ms. Xu: And don't use your hands. I know that's how you used to drink from the troughs, but here, it's very rude.
许娘子：但不能像当初在饮马的槽子里喝水那般，再用手捧水喝了。那是乡野村夫才做的事，明白了吗?

Ms. Xu: From now on, no matter if it's water, tea, or liquor, use a bowl. It's called manners.
许娘子：现下喝水，往后吃酒吃茶，都要用碗，这是礼法规矩，可乱不得。

Ms. Xu: Hmm, tomorrow I'll buy a bowl with your name on it, so you won't confuse yours with the others. And ask questions when you don't know what to do; don't just act on impulse like you did today. Understood?
许娘子：赶明儿我刻个有名字的碗给你，往后事事都要有教礼，不懂的就问人，切不能随了性子胡乱着来。

As she speaks, Ms. Xǔ tilts the liquor jar in her hand. With a gentle gurgling sound, the liquor streams like a string of glazed beads spilling onto a jade plate and fills the clay bowl of the patron in front of her.
话音落下，许娘子才再端起酒坛。只听得哗啦啦声响，那酒水泛出淡淡绿光，好似琉璃珠串落玉盘，顺流而下，盛满了一旁酒客的泥碗。

Old Drinker: Thank you!
酒翁：哎，谢谢咯——

Jiǔ watches intently, her eyes unblinking and nostrils flared. The ethereal aroma of the liquor wafts through the air, compelling her to reach out and scoop up a handful. Then, like a beast quenching its thirst, she tilts her head back and pours it into her mouth.
小九巴巴地瞧着，目不转睛，鼻尖翕动。空中属于酒水的香气似有若无地飘散，直引得她突然又伸出手去捞来一捧，再如牛饮一般飞快仰头倒进了嘴里。

Not a soul around her is quick enough to intervene. In an instant, an indescribable taste spreads across her tongue, unlike anything the child has ever tasted before.
而四周竟是无一人来得及阻止。霎时间，难以言说的味道在她唇舌间蔓延，和这小孩平日里吃过的任何东西都不一样。

Jiu: It, it's burning. It's burning my tongue. So hot!
小九：——它是辣的，好烫，好烫，舌头上有火在烧。

Jiu: Not sweet, not bitter—something's going into my nose!
小九：不苦也不甜，好像有东西在鼻子里打转。

Her throat instantly begins to burn, and tears and snot threaten to run from her eyes and nose. She scrunches up her face, fanning her mouth with her hand, and smacks her tongue against the roof of her mouth.
登时，那喉咙都要烫起来，眼泪鼻涕皆要往外窜，小九脸面皱起，连连甩手咂舌。

Jiu: Bleh—this is disgusting! It burns! Why do people like this?
小九：不喜欢，怎么会喜欢喝这么辣的东西?

Ms. Xu: Oh my—! Don't do that again, Jiǔ! And you're too young to understand why.
许娘子：你这孩子！罢了，以后可不许喝了，等到你再长些年岁，才会知晓这酒的个中滋味。

Ms. Xu: Besides, no one can drink this kind of thing every day ...
许娘子：况且，这辣东西也不是天天都能喝到的……

At this moment, a patroller enters the tavern, carrying a bundle of cloth in his hand.
这会儿，一位巡城郎走进酒坊中，手里提着个软布包袱。

He stands firm in the center of the hall, surveys the room, and heads straight for Ms. Xǔ.
站定厅中，扫视一圈后便径直走向许娘子。

Patroller: Ms. Xǔ, here are some old clothes from Lǐzhèng's family. All are gently used. He said to give it to the beggar.
巡城郎：许娘子，这是里正送来的一包旧衣物，说都是家眷余下的，皆有九成新，送予前日那乞儿穿。

Ms. Xu: She's not a beggar anymore. Her name is Jiǔ. Please send my thanks to Lǐzhèng.
许娘子：乞儿已不是乞儿，她叫小九哩。不过还是劳里正费心了，烦请代我向他问好。

Ms. Xu: And thank you too, sir. You've come all the way here; why not take a rest and have a drink?
许娘子：明日就是闲酒日了，到时我这酒坊就得半歇着，等下次放酒日还得半月后。

Ms. Xu: Tomorrow is the start of the liquor ban, so you'll have to wait half a month before we can serve you again.
许娘子：巡城走了这多长一路，还请坐下饮一杯，歇歇脚罢。

Patroller: But I'm still on duty ...
巡城郎：不了不了，还有公事在身……

Patroller: Oh, but could you fill my water bag for later? I'll drink with my friends after duty hours.
巡城郎：那便只把我这四两的酒囊灌一袋，今日散值后，同我兄弟饮。

As Ms. Xǔ opens the jar and pours the liquor, the patrons around her begin to whisper among themselves.
那许娘子开坛打酒的功夫，一旁的酒客们也窃窃聊起来。

Scholar Drinker: Liquor ban, liquor permit ... Look how we suffer from them!
酒书生：放酒日，闲酒日，苦了我们酒客的日子。

Old Drinker: All because of that d**n regulation—"No group drinking except holidays." If only they had just banned group drinking, but they've stopped all drinking altogether!
酒翁：唉，因那禁令，除了大小节，皆不能聚众饮酒。要是这般也就算了，可平日连私下喝酒也是不能的。

Old Drinker: We became friends by drinking together in this tavern, but because of the ban, we have less than two weeks a month when we can even drink!
酒翁：我们这些杜康旧友，原是喝一口，想一口的。细细算下来，每月间，倒有半月多的光景是碰不得酒的。

Scholar Drinker: Funny you say that, Mr. Shěn. I've seen you drinking a lot no matter on ban days or permit days.
酒书生：沈阿翁，你又逗乐了。不管闲酒、放酒日，你也没少一顿喝的。

Old Drinker: Shh! Watch your mouth ...
酒翁：嘘，可别瞎说——

The two patrons steal a glance at the patroller nearby, their voices fading to a whisper ...
两人瞥了一眼旁边的巡城郎，声音渐小下去……

The daylight hours fly by swiftly. Come nightfall, Jiǔ lies on her bed, soreness in her body and weariness in her legs. She has run back and forth through the front hall all day.
白日间的光景过得飞快。到了夜里，小九躺在床铺上，只感觉浑身酸痛，双脚乏力，这一日在前厅里不知跑了多少个来回。

Wooden Doll: In the darkness, the wooden dolls emerge once more, hopping onto the bed one after another and dancing beside her.
木头人：黑暗中，木头小人们不知又从哪里冒出来，接连蹦上床，在小九身边跳舞。

Wooden Dolls: Lying down! Lying down!
木头小人群：躺下了——躺下了——

Wooden Dolls: Working is exhausting; working is hard!
木头小人群：奔波劳累——做人难——

Wooden Dolls: How was the "business"?
木头小人：上工如何?

Jiu: "Business" is tiring. But there are interesting things! Dirty Things, West Hair, Crazy Sir ...
小九：上工好累～但也有好玩的，土窟窿，西边墙，狼官儿……

Jiu: These are very spicy liquors, you know.
小九：这些都是喝起来很辣的酒，你知道么?

Wooden Dolls: Don't know at all. Where is Xiángruì?
木头小人：不知道，不是要找祥瑞吗?

Wooden Dolls: Xiángruì, don't forget!
木头小人：别忘了，你。

Jiu: Stop rushing me. I'll look for it! The people here know so many things, especially Ms. Xǔ.
小九：别催我，我会去问的。那些人都知道好多东西呢，特别是老板娘。

Jiu: But, Xiángruì ... what exactly is a Xiángruì?
小九：不过祥瑞……到底什么是祥瑞呢?

6#1
6#1

闲时节
Idle Time CH16601-03

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, no customers today?
曲娘：啊呀，又是个没活儿干的日子。

Ms. Xu: Afraid not. We're on liquor ban after all.
许娘子：今日是闲酒日嘛……

Jiu Niangzi: Who decided what to do on different days, anyway? Isn't today just a normal day like any other?
曲娘：到底是谁发明的这些日子，初一、十五，上元、中元……每天不都是一样的么。

Much time passes ... Jiǔ has grown considerably taller, no longer bearing the feral appearance she once had. The patrons have bestowed upon her the nickname "Jiǔ Niángzǐ," regarding her as a young maiden charged with selling and serving liquor, and indeed, as Ms. Xǔ's successor.
一些日子没见，小九长高了不少，早就不是初来的野物模样。于是酒客们给了个“曲娘”的诨名，当她是沽酒的小女子，更是许三娘的接班人。

It didn't take long for her to shed her childhood demeanor. These days, she is immersed in the atmosphere of the tavern. She converses back and forth with the patrons with ease.
这些天来，她在酒坊耳濡目染，很快褪去当初街头乞儿的行态，如今也能跟客人说个有来有回。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ half-heartedly wipes the dust off the liquor jars, having counted the bowls behind the counter numerous times.
这会儿，曲娘正有一搭没一搭地擦着酒坛上的灰，柜台里的酒碗已被她点了好几遍。

She wanders the hall, idle and bored, and begins to read the "Regulations on Liquor Sale and Consumption" placard posted on one of the pillars.
她在门厅里晃悠着，闲得无聊，便读起柱子上贴着的《禁酤酒诏》。

Jiu Niangzi: I can't read it, save for a few characters. The customers talk about it all the time.
曲娘：我只认得里面的几个字，但这《禁酤酒诏》被客人们念叨过好多好多次。

Jiu Niangzi: So often that I can even recite it now: "This regulation aims to prioritize the use of grain for food over liquor ..."
曲娘：我都能背出来了：“酒醪之用，表节制于欢娱……”

Jiu Niangzi: Ms. Xǔ reads it during the liquor ban too, as if it could make the permit days come sooner.
曲娘：每到闲酒日，老板娘也会读一读，就好像多念一会儿，放酒的日子就会快点到一样。

The regulations are filled with verbose and tedious phrases, but it is only at the end that it clearly states:
那告示上皆是连篇累牍之词，只在最后写明——

"Citizens are permitted to drink during holidays and on the first and 15th days of the month. Drinking is prohibited on all other days, including group drinking, private drinking, and the sale of liquor in taverns."
“本城内，大小节日及初一十五为放酒日，饮酒不作限制；其余日子为闲酒日，民众不得聚众喝酒，也不得私自喝酒，酒坊亦不得兜售私酒。”

Jiu Niangzi: If not liquor, what else would be sold in a tavern? Whoever made this decision clearly doesn't understand what people want.
曲娘：酒坊不卖酒还能卖什么呢？想出这规矩的人真不灵光，一点都瞧不出大伙儿的所想所要。

Jiu Niangzi: Or do they? There are lots of rules here that don't let people do what they want. Is it on purpose?
曲娘：不过……别人越想做什么，就越不让别人做什么，金市的很多规矩都是如此……

Jiu Niangzi: Lǐzhèng manages the merchant hub ... Is he a guardian? Is he a Xiángruì?
曲娘：管着金市的里正，算是城里的庇护者吗？那他算不算祥瑞？

A knock echoes at the door. In accordance with the regulations, the tavern can only open the door halfway on liquor ban days.
门前传来叩门声，酒坊依照告示，闲酒日只得开半边门。

A patron slips into the front hall, flipping a few copper coins in hand and greeting like an old friend.
只见一个身影闪进前厅中，来人颠着手里的铜钱，自然地打招呼。

Citizen IV: Ms. Xǔ, I'll have three rice buns. The freshly made ones.
城中居民 IV：许娘子，来三个糟饼子，要刚出炉的，热乎乎的。

Citizen IV: Truly, no one makes better rice buns than you!
城中居民 IV：哎呀呀，还是你家的饼子香，吃一块要惦记三天。

Citizen IV: Can't you save me some next time? Every time I'm a little bit late, they're sold out.
城中居民 IV：每次都还要赶早来买，晚了就碰不上了。

On the table lies a large basket, brimming with small, golden, crispy buns with sesame seeds sprinkled on top. Here, they are known simply as rice buns.
酒坊前厅的桌上，摆着个大扁箩，里面堆着满满的小酥饼。酥饼黄澄澄，似是用米压成的，上面还撒了芝麻，此饼谓之“糟饼子”。

Ms. Xǔ moves as fast as serving liquor, picks out three rice buns, and hands them over to the patron.
许娘子快手快脚，和平时里上酒一样速度，拣了三个饼子交给来人。

Ms. Xu: Glad you like them. As you know, we can't do liquor business during the ban.
许娘子： 你们喜欢吃就好，也是靠邻里之间照顾生意。酒坊这闲酒日也不能干放着嘛。

Ms. Xu: Luckily, the rice we use to make liquor can be made into buns. We wouldn't be able to make a living if we didn't make these, and of course, if we didn't have your and the neighborhood's support.
许娘子： 幸而这酿酒余下的东西还能做成饼子。于是也当个营生拿来卖一阵，平日里手也就不闲着了。

Citizen IV: Hey, isn't this Jiǔ Niángzǐ? I thought you just slept in the back during the liquor ban.
城中居民 IV： 呦，曲娘也在帮忙，我还以为闲酒日你在后面睡觉呢。

Jiu Niangzi: Sleep? No work, no food. It's as simple as that.
曲娘： 睡觉？不上工就没吃的，这是世间最简单的道理。

Jiu Niangzi: So I need to work too. Sweep the floor, wipe the jars—all the cleaning, really.
曲娘： 我肯定也没歇着呀，扫地、搬酒一个没落下。

Citizen IV: Look at you, giving me a full speech.
城中居民 IV： 瞧你跟着许娘子，在酒坊里这几日，嘴巴都变利索了。

Citizen IV: I remember when you first got here. You could barely say a full sentence!
城中居民 IV： 想着当日你刚来酒坊那会儿，像个野地里的孩子，什么都不会。

Citizen IV: What a blessing it is that Ms. Xǔ took you in. She's fed and taught you all this time. Make sure you thank her properly when you've grown up, eh?
城中居民 IV： 许娘子对你是又管饭，又管教的。你真是托了她的福气，来日可得好好谢她。

Jiu Niangzi: Blessing ... Hmm, blessing ...
曲娘： 托了老板娘的福气，唔，福气……

Ms. Xǔ takes out a small cup and fills it with the tea from the teapot on the counter, inviting the visitor to drink it.
这会子，许娘子端出一小盅，从柜台的茶壶里倒了一杯清茶水，请来人解渴。

Citizen IV: Thank you. I always get thirsty on my trip over here ... My, what nice tea this is!
城中居民 IV： 每次到你这里就渴了，还是许娘子周到，这茶也是上品。

Citizen IV: A sip of clear tea like this is sure to melt the worries away. You really know how to run a business, Ms. Xǔ.
城中居民 IV： 一杯清茶顺咽喉，万事休矣莫再愁。

Ms. Xu: You flatter me. I'm just putting myself in the customer's shoes.
许娘子： 开店的就要有眼力见儿，想客人之所想。

Ms. Xu: It's the only way to run a long-lasting business. With the liquor ban ongoing, I'm counting on rice buns and tea to make a living.
许娘子： 如此生意才能长久，以后的日子里放酒日少，闲酒日多，我这酒坊还得靠这糟饼子的买卖过活呢。

Throughout the morning, a steady stream of customers come to buy her buns, until only seven or eight remain in the basket. Those who come too late truly will miss out.
这一日上午，陆陆续续又有不少来买糟饼的，一筐子麻糟饼也去了七八分，当真是来迟了就没有了。

After purchasing their buns, the patrons always make a point to drink a cup of tea in the tavern, draining it in one gulp. Only then do they leave contented.
来往客人除了买饼，总要在坊里喝杯茶，一饮而尽，随后才心满意足地走了。

Jiu Niangzi: Ms. Xǔ, the buns are selling quickly. Every time I go to the street, people ask me if there are any left.
曲娘：老板娘，我们的饼子卖得真快，每次出去，街上的人都问我有没有剩的。

Jiu Niangzi: Why don't we just sell buns instead of liquor? Then we wouldn't need to run around and serve the patrons.
曲娘：其实卖糟饼子也不错，不用跑来跑去招呼客人，也不用倒酒盛酒。

Jiu Niangzi: We'd just sit here and pass the buns to the customers.
曲娘：每日守在这里等着客人上门就行，要是可以一直卖饼子就好啦。

Ms. Xu: What are you talking about? We're running a tavern, not a bakery.
许娘子：你在想什么呢，曲娘，我们这是酒坊，又不是饼子铺。

Ms. Xu: People buy our buns because they're made in a tavern. If we didn't make liquor, we wouldn't have the ingredients to make them.
许娘子：别人买饼子，也是因为酒坊的名头，况且要是不卖酒了，这糟饼子的原料也没得来呀。

Jiu Niangzi: But aren't they made of rice?
曲娘：不就是和胡饼一样，用麦粉做的嘛。

The rice buns in the basket continue to emit their fragrance, a scent both familiar and foreign to Jiǔ Niángzǐ. She has never seen how these buns are made.
箩筐里的糟饼子还在散发着香味，对曲娘来说，这味道熟悉又陌生，不过她却从没见过这饼是怎么做成的。

She retires early each night, only to awaken to the enticing aroma the next morning. By then, Ms. Xǔ has already prepared a basket full of rice buns and is setting them up on the table.
她夜里都是早早睡了，只知道第二日闻着香儿起床，老板娘老早就做好一筐糟饼子摆上桌了。

Ms. Xu: Yes, but not entirely. They're made with the rice from the tavern.
许娘子：所谓糟饼子，和别家不同就在一个“糟”字。

Ms. Xu: We use grain to make liquor, including rice, wheat, millet, and many others.
许娘子：酒坊做酒，最看中的除了酿酒用的水，还有就是酿酒用的“米”了。黍米、秫米、糯米、稻米，都能酿酒。

Ms. Xu: You see, I always go to the grain store myself to get the best ingredients.
许娘子：你看我平日里从不让人送米来，都是亲自去粮坊里约米，为的就是挑好米。

Ms. Xu: After liquor is made, the lees left are called Jiǔniàng. Similar to your name. Rice buns are made of Jiǔniàng and buckwheat flour.
许娘子：米酿完酒后，就变成了酒糟。糟饼子就是用这新酒糟，还有荞麦粉，细细和在一起揉出来的。

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, I didn't know that. No wonder it smells better than other buns.
曲娘：原来酒糟也能做饼子，怪不得闻起来比胡饼香。

Ms. Xu: But it comes at a cost. Making buns is more tiring than making liquor!
许娘子：香是香，就是做起来呀，比酿酒还累人。

As she speaks, Ms. Xǔ playfully taps the tip of Jiǔ Niángzǐ's nose.
说着许娘子用手点一下曲娘的鼻子尖。

Ms. Xu: The freshly made rice buns taste the best. They lose their fragrance after a day.
许娘子：这糟饼子要刚出炉的才好吃，只放上一天，那香气就要走了大半。

Ms. Xu: To make the buns, we need to take the Jiǔniàng out of the liquor jar before three in the morning and mix the flour before five, knead and shape nearly a hundred of them, then heat the earthen oven and put them inside ...
许娘子：做这饼子，丑时便要把酒糟从缸里捞起来，寅时就要和面，然后生火，贴在土炉子里，每次要做百十来个。

Ms. Xu: I wouldn't have to work so hard if there were no liquor bans, let alone the neighborhood is counting on me to make the buns.
许娘子：要不是闲酒日没得营生，这一方邻里坊间又都指着饼子吃，我也没得这样累的。

Jiu Niangzi: Neighborhood is counting on you ...
曲娘：一方邻里坊间，都指望着老板娘做的糟饼子……

Jiu Niangzi: People need Ms. Xǔ ...
曲娘：众人都需要老板娘……

Though Ms. Xǔ speaks only of making buns and other mundane tasks, she gives her listener pause for thought.
许娘子虽讲的只是做饼这等日常闲事，但听者有想。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ's heart stirs, and she suddenly recalls the words of the Daoist.
曲娘闻言，心中不知怎么的，忽然想起那道士的话。

Jiu Niangzi: Ms. Xǔ, do you know what a Xiángruì is?
曲娘：老板娘，你知道祥瑞是什么东西吗?

Jiu Niangzi: I heard that it's something good.
曲娘：我听人说，那好像是个很好的东西。

Ms. Xu: Where did you hear about that? Oh, from the drinkers, of course.
许娘子：你怎么问起这个了，哦，肯定是那些酒客嘴里蹦出的市井闲谈。

Ms. Xu: They're just drunk and talking nonsense. Don't take it seriously.
许娘子：他们喝了酒，十句有八句是胡诌的，你平时可不能当真。

Ms. Xu: But I have heard about Xiángruì. They say they're divine beasts, guardians with special power.
许娘子：不过祥瑞……早些年我也听人说过。祥瑞就是庇佑一方的神兽，有些神奇的法力。

Jiu Niangzi: Have you seen it before? Can I see it?
曲娘：那老板娘见过祥瑞吗？我能去见祥瑞吗?

Upon hearing that Ms. Xǔ holds some insight on Xiángruì, Jiǔ Niángzǐ becomes quite agitated, eagerly moving closer to her.
一听见老板娘有所了解，曲娘变得颇为激动，直往这边凑。

Ms. Xǔ has no choice but to guide Jiǔ Niángzǐ to first take a seat before she begins speaking to her properly.
许娘子只得先把曲娘按住坐下，再跟她好好说话。

Ms. Xu: Easy, girl. There's not much I can tell you.
许娘子：好了好了，莫要冲动。关于祥瑞我也是一知半解。

Ms. Xu: The frequenters said that, before the bridge was broken, this city had a Xiángruì as a guardian.
许娘子：只是听说，城外那桥在断前，也有个祥瑞一直庇护这方城池。

Ms. Xu: It looked like a horse, and it ran faster than the wind. But its story is long lost to time; no one knows if it's real.
许娘子：据说这祥瑞样子和马很像，跑得比风还快。不过这都是很早以前的事了，我也是听酒坊里的老客人说起过，不知真假。

Jiu Niangzi: Do you know what a Xiángruì does? Or how to become one?
曲娘：那祥瑞会做什么？怎么才能变成祥瑞?

Ms. Xu: Um, just like in every story, they help people when they need it and disappear soon after they're safe.
许娘子：至于祥瑞会做什么，大概就和神话书上的差不多吧，人有难时它就会出现，助完人后就不见了。

Ms. Xu: As for how to become one ... They're monsters and Yāos. I've never heard of a person becoming a Xiángruì.
许娘子：至于变成祥瑞……祥瑞基本都是精怪神物所化，哪有人能变成祥瑞的。

Seeing Jiǔ Niángzǐ sitting there with her ears perked up, she dares not hold back a single word.
见曲娘竖起耳朵，一个字也不敢落下。

Ms. Xu: You're just like that boy from the silk store. He, too, could listen to the stories of Yāos and monsters all day long.
许娘子：你呀，就跟前门绸铺的小儿一个样，整天就对神仙列传、妖怪传说之类的感兴趣。

Ms. Xu: He asks people about the stories in The Classic of Mountains and Seas every single day. Little by little, he learned how to read without ever going to school.
许娘子：那小儿天天拿着本《山海经》问东问西，时间久了，倒也把一本书的字识全了，还省了上学堂的钱。

Ms. Xu: If you want to know more about Xiángruì, maybe Mr. Liǔ from the clinic can help. He's knowledgeable. He might be able to teach you how to read.
许娘子：你要真想弄明白什么祥瑞之类的，就去问问街尾医馆的柳郎君，他博学多见，你也跟他顺便学学认字。

Ms. Xu: And then you can help me with the bookkeeping or writing toasts.
许娘子：到时候帮我看看账本，写些祝酒词也是好的。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ feels a surge of joy within her. If she could read, then she could read books, and, as she has heard many say, books contain absolutely everything—surely, that includes everything about the Xiángruì, too.
听闻此，曲娘自然是心生欢喜，识字了就能看书，听别人说，书里什么都写了，想必祥瑞之事也在上面有所记载。

Without hesitation, she agrees and promptly sets out to find Mr. Liǔ.
于是当下应了，旋即就要出门去找柳郎君。

Ms. Xu: Oh, before you go, take this.
许娘子：诶，先不忙出门。你先过来。

Ms. Xǔ pulls out a sheet of jute paper, carefully wraps twelve buns within it, and ties it up.
许娘子把张黄麻纸拿出来，细细拣了十二个糟饼子，仔细包好，又用绳子捆了打个结儿。

She then takes out some coins and asks Jiǔ Niángzǐ to give them to Mr. Liǔ together with the buns.
除了这一包饼，许娘子又拿出一把铜钱，让曲娘交给柳郎君。

Jiu Niangzi: Are the coins for medicine? Are you sick?
曲娘：老板娘你生病了？怎么还要让柳郎君抓药?

Ms. Xu: No, silly, it's not for me. It's for the favor you're about to ask.
许娘子：你这傻孩子，这不是让你买药，这是人情。

Ms. Xu: Sweetie, when you're asking someone for a favor, you don't come empty-handed. That's one manner in socializing. You still have a lot to learn.
许娘子：但凡托人办事呢，可不能吃白食，人情往来，最是重要……你要学的还多着呢。

Jiu Niangzi: So, buns and money equal good etiquette?
曲娘：一包饼子，一溜子钱就叫作人情了。

Jiu Niangzi: How strange. It is heavy to carry.
曲娘：唔……人情真奇怪，提在手里还怪累的。

As the half-moon wanes and the new moon rises, the streets bustle with life. Now, on each liquor ban afternoon, Jiǔ Niángzǐ visits the clinic at the end of the street to meet Mr. Liǔ and learn the art of letters and words.
捻指过了半月，刚过朔日，街上人来人往。如今，每到闲酒日的下午，曲娘就来街尾的医馆，找柳郎君学文识字。

To avoid disturbing the clinic's work, Jiǔ Niángzǐ often brings a small stool to sit on by the doorway.
为了不影响馆内看病，曲娘每每便支个小凳坐在门口边上。

Jiu Niangzi: "As warmth fades, the cold follows, the autumn harvest begins ..."
曲娘：“寒来暑往，秋收……”

Jiu Niangzi: "Autumn harvest begins" ... and, um, ...
曲娘：秋收……秋收什么来着……

Mr. Liu: "And we hoard food for winter." Jiǔ Niángzǐ, are you still having trouble reciting Thousand Character Classic?
柳郎君：秋收冬藏。曲娘，今日的《千字文》念得如何了？

Mr. Liu: I'm confused. You learn everything quickly, except for reading. Every time I teach you how to read something, you forget it right away.
柳郎君：你别的地方倒是聪慧，学得也快，怎么认字就特别慢了，像是之前从没见过字似的。

Mr. Liu: I suppose not everyone is gifted enough to read.
柳郎君：由此可见，学文还是要看老天赐赋的。

Jiu Niangzi: Reading is so much harder than serving liquor. I always get a headache when I start reading something ...
曲娘：认字比打酒难多了，我脑袋里像发了个面团，一看见字就涨疼。

Jiu Niangzi: And these characters look like earthworms ...
曲娘：而且这些字歪歪扭扭，好像地龙虫儿。

Mr. Liu: "Sky black, earth golden. Vast universe, limitless cosmos." Knowledge and culture were easily lost before Cāngjié invented characters. Through reading these "earthworms," wisdom, discipline, and manners have been passed down for generations.
柳郎君：“天地玄黄，宇宙洪荒”，自仓颉造字起，才开了智能，圣人训诫才能流传下来，条律才有了记录，人所得礼法。

Mr. Liu: One is not civilized until one is able to read—able to read the books of the sages at that.
柳郎君：识了字，读圣贤书，方才开化。要是不识字，连药书也看不懂，更别说像我一般开医馆了。

Jiu Niangzi: That Cāngjié sounds like a bad guy.
曲娘：那造字的人挺坏的。

Jiu Niangzi: He could've made the characters easier to read if he really wanted people to learn.
曲娘：又想让人认字，又不把字造得简单些。

Mr. Liu: ...
柳郎君：……

Jiu Niangzi: Mr. Liǔ, do you know what a Xiángruì is? Ms. Xǔ said that you're knowledgeable and would be able to answer my questions.
曲娘：柳郎君，你知道祥瑞是什么吗？酒坊老板娘说你博古通今，什么都知道。

Mr. Liu: The so called Xiángruì ...
柳郎君：所谓祥瑞，祥瑞嘛……

Mr. Liǔ pauses momentarily. Fortunately, his proclivity for reading allows him to address the question with ease, thus preserving his dignity in front of the young lady.
柳郎君顿上一顿，所幸他平日里就爱看些杂书，对这问题信手拈来，才没在这小娘子跟前拂了面子。

Mr. Liu: ... also known as "the sign of auspiciousness." When it appears, it's a good omen from heaven, and things will go well.
柳郎君：祥瑞又称“福瑞”，意为吉祥征兆，乃是上天传授乐善之天意，于人有益的征兆。

Mr. Liu: But its form is unpredictable. It could be a colorful cloud, two-spike wheat, or a dry spring that somehow flourishes. Under some circumstances, it could even be an exotic beast.
柳郎君：不过祥瑞之形变化无端，有天降彩云的，有禾生双穗的，有地涌甘泉的，当然，也有奇珍异兽出现的。

The phrase "exotic beast" strikes Jiǔ Niángzǐ like a hammer, prompting her to inquire further.
“奇珍异兽”这四字像是一记惊堂木，让曲娘忙追问起来。

Jiu Niangzi: Oh! Do you know how an animal becomes a Xiángruì?
曲娘：那奇珍异兽，怎么变成祥瑞呢?

Mr. Liu: Uh, um ... How could I know? The books I read are the philosophical studies of sages and scholars, not monster stories for children.
柳郎君：这，这……这我也不清楚，读圣贤书的，怎么知道这些杂文野史的细节。

Jiu Niangzi: Then you don't know anything either. I thought you knew everything.
曲娘：那你也是什么都不知道的，老板娘让我来这里，还以为能学到些什么。

These words leave Mr. Liǔ speechless. All he can do is scratch his head.
曲娘两句话把柳郎君问得说不出话，只能干挠头。

Suddenly, he remembers that there are other ways to chronicle the world's wonders besides words. He strides into the clinic and reemerges with several dusty, time-worn tomes in hand.
柳郎君忽想到，这世上的东西，除了用文字记下，当然还有别的方式。于是他便往医馆里去，没一会儿就拿着几本沾灰的书走出来。

As he unfurls their pages, they reveal coarsely printed illustrations of mountain spirits and wild monsters, each annotated in a diminutive square script.
打开一看，里面都是些山精野怪的图画，配着小小的方块字。印制粗糙，连封面都残破不堪。

Mr. Liu: Here, these are picture books about the monster stories you like. There's only a little text.
柳郎君：喏，就这些，都是些讲山精野怪、民间传言的书。上面字不多，尽是图画。

Mr. Liu: You can research the Xiángruì legends while learning some characters. Two birds, one stone, and all that.
柳郎君：你呢，正好一边学学字，一边也找找你要的祥瑞，正所谓一举两得。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ takes the book and cradles it gently in her hands. She turns the pages in awe.
曲娘接过书，小心捧着翻看。

Seizing this quiet moment, Mr. Liǔ takes out two rice buns and places a large bowl on the counter.
趁着空当，柳郎君便拿出两块糟饼子，又拿出一只大碗放在柜台上。

Jiu Niangzi: I want a rice bun, too.
曲娘：咦，是糟饼子，我也想吃。

Mr. Liu: So you can drink. I thought Ms. Xǔ said you didn't like the taste of liquor.
柳郎君：我记得许娘子说你不爱喝酒，这几日不见，酒量着实见长。

Mr. Liu: Even the most experienced drinker can't eat a rice bun without water.
柳郎君：想是我们最能喝的老翁，也不敢空口吃糟饼子。

Jiu Niangzi: What are you talking about? I don't drink. I just want to know what the rice buns taste like. Ms. Xǔ's never let me have one before.
曲娘：你说什么呀？老板娘从不给我吃糟饼子，我从没吃过呢，所以好奇。

Mr. Liu: Oh dear, so Ms. Xǔ didn't tell you. I fear I've said too much ...
柳郎君：看来你们老板娘还没跟你提过，我这一说会不会……

Mr. Liu: But you do live in the tavern and help her do all the work. It's only a matter of time before you find out ... Alright, I'll show you.
柳郎君：也罢，你要帮衬着老板娘，经营酒坊的话，不论早晚也是要知道的。

Mr. Liǔ carefully crumbles a rice bun into the bowl. He then pours hot tea over it, and a familiar aroma wafts into Jiǔ Niángzǐ's nostrils.
但见柳郎君拿一块糟饼子细细掰碎了，落在碗里，约莫盛了有个半碗，随着一壶热茶水冲入碗里，熟悉的香味漫入曲娘的鼻子。

That mellow fermented fragrance, mixed with the dry scent of sesame and the smoky aroma of the roasted hearth, fills the air.
醇厚的酿造芬香，夹着芝麻的干香和炙烤过的炉气。

Jiu Niangzi: Whoa, the water turns the bun into liquor!
曲娘：咦，热茶把饼变成了酒。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ leans over the counter, her delicate face reflected in the bowl. The rice bun has dissolved, leaving only a few grains at the bottom of the bowl.
曲娘凑在柜台边，小小的面庞倒映碗中，糟饼子已经溶化，只余一些酒糟粒沉在茶碗底。

Mr. Liu: Because of the liquor ban, we can't directly buy liquor, so Ms. Xǔ came up with this rice bun idea.
柳郎君：许娘子为了照顾我们这些老酒客，专门做成了这糟饼子。

Mr. Liu: The Jiǔniàng used in the buns is specially made, keeping most of the alcohol in it, so that the bun has a strong smell of alcohol.
柳郎君：听说这糟饼子用的酒糟是特意酿的几缸，专是出糟多，出酒少。所以这糟饼子才能如此酒气十足。

Mr. Liu: Eating it is like drinking distilled alcohol; only a drunkard could handle that.
柳郎君：空口吃饼，定要吃得满脸红，只有那老酒蒙子才敢吃。

Mr. Liu: But watering it down makes it easy to drink. A bowl of this liquor can take all your worries away.
柳郎君：不过要是兑上水，只一碗，就成了一口解忧消愁的美酒。

Jiu Niangzi: So that's why people come and buy buns during the liquor ban.
曲娘：原来如此，怪不得每到闲酒日，那么多人来买饼。

Jiu Niangzi: Ms. Xǔ is so clever. What a creative way to give people drinks!
曲娘：老板娘真厉害，能想出这个办法送酒给人喝。

Mr. Liu: Drinking a bowl or two and getting lost in our own thoughts. This is one of a few entertainments for us common people.
柳郎君：闲暇时酌上一两杯，暂时遨游世外，老百姓平日里就这一点喜好了。

Mr. Liu: The liquor ban has led to some inventive ways for people to get their liquor.
柳郎君：这禁酒令让百姓们寻找各种法子，与官府斗智斗勇。

Mr. Liu: Luckily, the government is not very strict about it, and thanks to Ms. Xǔ, drinkers like us can have a sip when we want.
柳郎君：不过好在查得倒是不严，又有你们老板娘的有勇有谋，才让我们能有一口喝的。

Jiu Niangzi: I never knew that ... Ms. Xǔ is really helping people.
曲娘：原来……老板娘在帮酒客们，我今天才知道。

Jiu Niangzi: I should do that too. As soon as I get back to the tavern, I'll tell her that I'll help her deliver the buns.
曲娘：我也该帮大家喝上一口酒的，对了，我回去就跟老板娘说，我也跟着她一起送酒给大家。

This spirited young girl, showing such audacity in her utter indifference to the laws against liquor, earns nothing but admiration from Mr. Liǔ.
这小娘子竟然有如此胆气，全然不在乎禁酒的诏令，柳郎君也不禁佩服。

Mr. Liu: But remember, you didn't hear this from me.
柳郎君：不过这糟饼子的秘密，千万别说是我跟你提的。

Jiu Niangzi: You didn't tell me anything. I figured it out myself.
曲娘：保管一个字也不说，只说是我自己闻出来的。

6#1
6#1

存身之处
A Place to Belong CH16601-04

Time slips away, and despite the arrival of another liquor ban day, the tavern seems busier than usual.
光阴过隙，经此一段时间，虽到了闲酒日，但酒坊中似乎比平时还要忙。

It is only morning, and the tavern is already bustling with life. The door stands ajar, as per tradition, allowing the scent of sesame to drift outward as fresh rice buns tumble into baskets, their steam coiling into the air.
早晨，酒坊中早已开工，大门依规矩还只开半扇，一只只新出炉的糟饼子落入箩筐中，伴着芝麻香的热气袅袅升起。

Unlike previous days, another petite figure waits nearby, wearing light walking shoes and carrying a soft cloth bundle.
与往日不同，除了劳作的许娘子，另一个小小身影早就等在一旁，脚上换了轻便的行步鞋，怀里还携着个软布包袱。

Ms. Xu: 41, 42, 43 ...
许娘子：四十一、四十二、四十三……

Ms. Xu: 50 rice buns in total, fresh out of the oven. Smells good; worth the hard work. I was up before the sun.
许娘子：好，一共五十个糟饼子，新出炉热乎的，上好的酒糟做成。这香气扑面，不枉我天不亮就起床揉面。

Ms. Xu: Do you think you can make it? You'll have to walk through basically half the city to deliver all the buns.
许娘子：今日送的要走大半个沛城，你还能行么？

Jiu Niangzi: Don't worry, it's not my first time. I'll run as fast as I can!
曲娘：我都送了多少次了，别担心，我会跑着送的。

Ms. Xu: Still remember our customers and their orders?
许娘子：那你还记得要送哪几家么？

Jiu Niangzi: Sure I do. Two buns for the butcher on West Street, four for the tea room on South Alley, the family across the bridge wants three, and, um ...
曲娘：当然记得，西街的肉铺要两块饼，南巷的茶坊要四块，宝袋桥边那家要三块，还有，还有……

Jiǔ Niángzǐ retrieves a piece of paper from her sleeve, upon which a map has been haphazardly drawn, marking the locations of the shops she must deliver to today.
曲娘自袖口里拿出一张纸，上面歪歪斜斜画了地图，写了今日要送的铺子方位。

Jiu Niangzi: See, I wrote it down. Since I've learned how to read and write, I can remember them easily!
曲娘：瞧，我都记下了。会识字是有好处的，写在纸上比记在头脑中有用多了。

Upon closer inspection, the list would give most people a good laugh. Aside from a few familiar characters, the rest is made up of drawings resembling an encrypted espionage missive.
近看那清单的人定要发笑，上面除了几个常用的字，其余全是用画画代替的，好似是探子的加密文书。

It is highly unlikely that anyone but her would be able to decipher it.
除了本酒坊的曲娘，想必城里再找不出第二个人能看懂。

Ms. Xu: Be careful. Stay alert to the patrollers. If you're thirsty, just ask for a cup of tea when you get to the tea room. The owner will give you one.
许娘子：早去早回，遇见巡城的就慢些走，去茶坊送时，顺便找老板要碗茶喝，解解渴。

Jiu Niangzi: Yeah, alright.
曲娘：知道了，知道了。

Before she finishes her sentence, Jiǔ Niángzǐ is dashing out the door, taking huge swift strides as she runs down the street and disappears into the distance. Compared to that little beggar of years past, she looks like a completely different person.
话没说完，曲娘就三步并作两步跑出门，沿着长街跑远了，当真是脚力快，那身影与几年前的街头乞儿相比，仿若隔世。

Without Jiǔ Niángzǐ's help, it would not be possible to deliver rice buns to people in other districts of the city. Ms. Xǔ shines with gratitude.
也是亏得曲娘帮忙，才能给城里其他坊区的百姓送上糟饼子，许娘子感慨着。

Jiu Niangzi: Hmm, should I go east or west first? Or I could start with the closer ones, and then the farther ones ...
曲娘：我想一想，是先送东边，还是先送西边？或者先送近的，再送远的……

Jiu Niangzi: So many orders to deliver. So many people to meet.
曲娘：今天要去那么多的铺子人家，要见那么多的人。

Amidst her musings, a wooden doll peeks its head out from the sleeve of her garment.
正自言自语间，一个木头小人儿从曲娘的衣袖里探出脑袋。

Wooden Dolls: And things about Xiángruì to ask. Don't forget!
木头小人：打听祥瑞，别忘了。

Jiu Niangzi: Oh right, Xiángruì. I need to ask around.
曲娘：对，祥瑞，我也要问问。

Jiu Niangzi: Hey, I didn't call you. Why did you come out? Hide; quickly!
曲娘：诶，我都没叫你，你怎么自己跑出来了，赶紧躲起来。

After tucking the wooden doll back into her sleeve, Jiǔ Niángzǐ spends half the day running through the city and delivers over half of the rice buns.
把木头小人塞回衣袖后，曲娘在城内跑了小半日，糟饼子送出一半多。

Now, guided by her own map, she arrives at the edge of an alley and knocks on a weathered wooden door.
这会儿她依着自己的地图，走到一处街巷边，叩响了一扇斑驳的木门。

Poet: Coming, I'm coming! Finally, the font of my inspiration has arrived.
酒诗人：来了，来了，这可正是才思如泉涌的时候，偏偏这时候。

Poet: I've been waiting all day, Jiǔ Niángzǐ.
酒诗人：是曲娘嘛，我等了许久了。

Jiu Niangzi: Mr. Lǐ, the buns you ordered are here.
曲娘：李官郎，这是我们酒坊送来的两块糟饼子。

Poet: Great, great. I'll get water to mix them together.
酒诗人：甚好，甚好，待我拿茶来泡了。

Mr. Lǐ's hands are stained with ink, and looking in from the doorway, the room appears to be strewn with sheets of white rice paper, the fresh ink still glistening on their surfaces.
只见李官郎双手沾墨，从门口这儿朝内望去，屋里桌上椅上，全散着白花花的宣纸，上面的墨渍还未干。

In the tavern, where the town's drinkers gather, none are unaware of the poetic talents of Mr. Lǐ. A lover of verse and ink, he often likens himself to the great poets, Du Fu and Li Bai.
但凡去酒坊喝酒的人，无人不知这诗才李官郎。那是个最爱写诗弄墨的主儿，常常自比杜甫李白。

Jiu Niangzi: Mr. Lǐ, are you still writing poems?
曲娘：李官郎，你还在写诗吗?

Poet: The tavern was too noisy. By the time I got home, my inspirations had all been driven away. Luckily, today is liquor ban day, so I woke up with a clearer mind.
酒诗人：前几日酒坊里闹哄哄的，每日回来便没有头绪。今日正逢闲酒日，倒是一早便觉头脑清澈。

Poet: I woke up before seven this morning and started creating right away. But hot liquor will help my ideas flow. Thanks for the buns!
酒诗人：卯时就起了，于是研墨挥毫，一气作了不少出来。诗意正浓，还得两碗热酒更助吾兴。幸而有你送的糟饼子。

Mr. Lǐ dissolves a rice bun in tea, and with a single gulp, he drinks it down. Within moments, a flush of color spreads across his face.
李官郎用茶水把饼子溶了，一饮而尽，一两时，面色便红润了几分。

Poet: Excellent! What a drink. What an excellent mood I'm in now!
酒诗人：快意，快意，待我挥毫再写上几首。

Witnessing this scene, Jiǔ Niángzǐ's curiosity is piqued. Since she started working at the tavern, she has seen all manner of drinkers, yet she remains unaware of the reasons behind their indulgence.
见此情状，曲娘心中好奇。自从在酒坊里上工以来，她见过各式酒客，但依旧不知道他们喝酒的缘由所在。

Jiu Niangzi: People say drinking makes you smarter. Is that so?
曲娘：他们说，李官郎喝酒后就变得有才气，是不是真的?

Poet: I can't speak for others, but it doesn't make me smarter, but bolder. Often, without drinking, I feel fettered, and I can't write a single word.
酒诗人：别的人我不知，只是这酒之于我，不是才气，而是胆气。提笔写诗时总有顿塞之时，每字必斟酌半日，迟迟不落笔。

Poet: But a bowl of liquor emboldens me, like I'm a general riding a horse, running on the field of creativity.
酒诗人：可等那一壶酒下肚，像有了一股胆气，仿若变了个将军，用字用词全凭意气。

Poet: And somehow, the poems I write when I'm in this mood are better than the others.
酒诗人：如此一来，倒也能写出些好诗。

Jiu Niangzi: Sounds like liquor can give people energy.
曲娘：你这么一说，美酒好像真的能壮胆呢。

Jiu Niangzi: The guests are always energetic and loud after drinking.
曲娘：所以酒坊的客人一喝酒，就吵吵闹闹，声音也大起来。

Poet: By the way, I heard you've been studying with Mr. Liǔ. Why didn't you come to me?
酒诗人：对了，听闻曲娘你在柳郎君那里学写字念文，怎的不找我来教?

Poet: I'm much more accomplished than him—intelligent and erudite. Let me read something to you: Goose, goose, goose ...
酒诗人：我定比那人强上百倍，待我给你念上两首你就知道了。天上之水天上来……

Jiǔ Niángzǐ hastily excuses herself, saying that she still has many buns to deliver, and scurries away.
闻此言，曲娘自然是赶紧推脱，忙说自己还有许多饼子没送，一溜烟也似的跑了。

Thus, Jiǔ Niángzǐ traverses several streets more until she arrives at another household and knocks on the door.
如此这般，她又走了几条街，来到另一户人家这里敲开门。

Her knock resounds. The door is opened by an elderly man with graying hair—a familiar face often seen at the tavern.
闻声，一位头发花白的老翁打开门，正是酒坊里的常见客，老熟人。

Old Drinker: Finally! The taste of the rice bun liquor lingers in my mouth for days. Using half a bun a day is equal to four days' drinking!
酒翁：哎呦呦，我总想着念着这口糟饼子泡的酒。还好送来了，今日泡半只，明日半只，也够我喝上四天了。

Old Drinker: Thank you, Jiǔ Niángzǐ, for delivering them for me. And send my thanks to Ms. Xǔ as well.
酒翁：劳烦曲娘还跑了老远的路，给我这个老头子送饼。也替我谢过你们许娘子。

As Jiǔ Niángzǐ hands over the rice buns, she suddenly recalls the wooden doll's admonition.
曲娘递过饼子，忽想起木头小人的嘱咐。

Jiu Niangzi: Mr. Shěn, could you tell me more about the Xiángruì you mentioned in the tavern that day?
曲娘：沈阿翁，上次在酒坊提到的祥瑞，还能再讲讲吗?

Jiu Niangzi: Ms. Xǔ told me you've met a lot of people and know a lot of things. Maybe that includes a story about Xiángruì, too.
曲娘：老板娘说你见过很多人呀，事呀，所以知道祥瑞的故事。

Old Drinker: Why are you suddenly asking me this? But she's right that I know many things.
酒翁：怎的问起这个？不过说我酒翁所见得多，也确是实话。

Old Drinker: It is an age-old story. Every Xiángruì looks different, resides in different locations, and has their own duty.
酒翁：这祥瑞是早就有的，各地祥瑞模样不同，不过都是带着职责而来的。

Jiu Niangzi: From what I know, a Xiángruì blesses its people. But how does the blessing work?
曲娘：我知道，祥瑞要庇佑一方百姓，不过这个“庇佑”要怎么做?

Old Drinker leans against the door frame. For some time, he strokes his whiskers as he contemplates how to give Jiǔ Niángzǐ a satisfactory answer.
酒翁扶着门框想了半晌，摸着脸颊络腮胡，考虑怎么给曲娘一个好回答。

Old Drinker: The blessing, I'd say, satisfies the wishes of the people.
酒翁： 要说“庇佑”，可能就是满足百姓的心愿吧……

Old Drinker: Like Ms. Xǔ and her tavern. She provides a place for drinkers like me to enjoy liquor and makes these rice buns when drinking is banned.
酒翁： 好比你家的许三娘和那座酒坊，给了我们这些酒蒙子们一个喝酒的地方，又在不放酒的日子里偷偷送来糟饼子。

Old Drinker: She is such a blessing, with much more bark than bite. And the liquor she makes is so smooth, it whisks away my sorrows.
酒翁： 所以许娘子应该就算是我们的庇佑了吧，嘴巴上利落，心里却善。在她那里喝上一杯佳酿，世上烦心事都飘走了。

Old Drinker then falls into reminiscence as he begins muttering to himself.
说到此处，老翁像是陷入了回忆，独自念叨起来。

Old Drinker: Liquor ... I suppose liquor is a good thing. It comforts people.
酒翁： 酒哇，酒哇是个好东西，酒能给人安慰。

Old Drinker: I was once too young to enjoy it, and now I'm too old to enjoy life.
酒翁： 年轻时不识酒滋味，等我这个年纪，总念着过去，又忧心将来。

Old Drinker: Only a bowl of liquor can take me back to enjoying that youth that I can only visit in my dreams.
酒翁： 唯有一杯浊酒下肚，浑浑噩噩间，仿佛回了过去，了结心愿愁绪。

As the sun is setting and Jiǔ Niángzǐ still has several rice buns yet to deliver, she bids farewell to Old Drinker and hurries off. As she glances back, she sees him sitting by the door, cradling his rice buns and liquor, and softly humming a tune.
那会儿日头正西移，还有几块糟饼子未送，曲娘不敢耽搁时间，与沈阿翁告别，但回目看去，老者端了糟饼酒，坐在门边，慢哼一首曲儿。

On her journey, Jiǔ Niángzǐ contemplates the "blessing" Old Drinker mentioned. Guided by her map, she unknowingly steps onto the threshold of the last house on her list.
一路上曲娘都在想沈阿翁说的“庇佑”，凭着地图，不知不觉又踏入了要送的最后一家。

Zhici
职祠

Jiu Niangzi: Ms. Xǔ runs the tavern to satisfy people's wishes to drink ... Is that a "blessing"?
曲娘： 老板娘开酒坊，让大家的心愿满足，能喝酒，这就是“庇佑”。

Jiu Niangzi: To become a Xiángruì, I need to ...
曲娘： 如果要成为祥瑞的话，就得……

Lost in thought, Jiǔ Niángzǐ finds her path obstructed by a formidable figure. The man, out of habit, presses down on the short sword at his waist, adjusts its position, and clears his throat to remind her of his presence.
曲娘这般想着，却被一个威武身影挡住了去路，那人习惯性压下腰间的短剑，调整了别剑姿势，又哼了两声提醒。

Facao: Seeing that Jiǔ Niángzǐ is still lost in her reverie, the man clears his throat once more.
法曹： 见曲娘依旧神游世外，便又哼了一声来。

Facao: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, you're late.
法曹： 你来晚了，曲娘。

Facao: Two hours late. Lucky for you, Lǐzhèng is still working on the ledger of the New Year's purchase.
法曹：晚了一个时辰，幸而今天里正在审年节用度账册上花了这么些时间。

Jiu Niangzi: Fǎ-Fǎcáo, why are you here? What's late?
曲娘：这，法曹，你怎么在这儿，什么来晚了？

Jiu Niangzi: I'm just, um, wandering on the street. I don't know what you're talking about.
曲娘：我只是从外街……逛到这里，不明白你说的什么意思。

Recalling Ms. Xǔ's words, she quickly takes a step back to distance herself from him.
那时间，曲娘记起许娘子说的话，赶忙撇干净关系，退后几步。

Facao: You have around seven or eight buns with you, do you not? You can give them to me now.
法曹：给我吧，你那儿应该还有七八个糟饼子吧。

Jiu Niangzi: ...
曲娘：……

After a moment's hesitation, Jiǔ Niángzǐ hands over the rest of the buns, her heart pounding in her chest, anticipating the judgment of the law.
曲娘迟疑片刻，还是把软布包袱里的糟饼子都给了出去，不过心里已死灰一片，只等法曹发落。

Unsure of what the punishment might be for breaking the liquor ban, Jiǔ Niángzǐ waits silently.
不知这违抗禁酒令者，该如何判罚……曲娘心里默想着。

But he does not blame her. Instead, he fishes out seven or eight copper coins from his person and counts them out before presenting them to her.
怎料那法曹却自身上摸出七八枚铜钱，点了交给曲娘。

Jiu Niangzi: This is ...?
曲娘：这是……

Facao: It's for the buns. We officers aren't freeloaders.
法曹：拿着，饼子的钱，我们官职不拿白食的。

Facao: Hurry. Take this.
法曹：快些接着。

Jiu Niangzi: Um, they're rice buns ... made from the materials from making liquor, if you just eat them like that—
曲娘：呃，这是我们酒坊的糟饼子，用上好的酒糟和荞麦粉做成，要是直接吃下去……

Facao: I know. Yesterday I sent someone to the tavern and asked that they be sent to the Zhící.
法曹：我知道，是我昨日派人去酒坊定的，让今天送到职祠来。

Facao: I expected you to arrive earlier.
法曹：我记得你脚力不是挺快的嘛，怎么还是迟到了。

Facao: A member of the patrol team just got promoted. We've been waiting for this to celebrate—
法曹：巡城队里的手下刚升职，今晚要好好庆贺一番，就指望这口——

As he speaks, a figure emerges from the Zhící, exuding an air of authority and kindness. It is Lǐzhèng. Jiǔ Niángzǐ hasn't seen him for quite some time.
正说着，自职祠室内走出一人，模样威正，又透出慈祥和蔼，恰是曲娘许久未见的里正。

Lizheng: My work is done here. Time to head back, Fǎcáo.
里正：年节用度账册已审毕，可以返程了，法曹。

Lizheng: Hmm? Isn't this Jiǔ Niángzǐ? You've grown up now.
里正：嗯？这不是曲娘么，约莫有这么久没见，已经出落到这么大了。

Lizheng: I heard you're doing a good job in the tavern. The patrollers always talk about you.
里正：听闻你在酒坊里干得不错，路过的巡城郎回来总提起你。

Jiu Niangzi: Thank you, Lǐzhèng.
曲娘：见过里正。

Lizheng: But what are you two talking about? Is there something I should know?
里正：不过法曹和曲娘在此处说些什么话，莫不是有什么要事?

Facao: ...
法曹：……

Jiu Niangzi: N-nothing! I'm just asking Fǎcáo about, um, about ...
曲娘：没有，没有，我只是向法曹，向法曹打听本地的……

Jiu Niangzi: About Xiángruì! I've been studying with Mr. Liǔ these days and saw the word "Xiángruì." It's said to be some divine beast that protects people, but nothing more.
曲娘：“祥瑞”！我最近跟柳郎君学识字，看见书中有“祥瑞”一词，只知道是保佑一方的瑞兽，不过不知具体模样形状。

Jiu Niangzi: So I was asking him about the Xiángruì in Pèi City.
曲娘：我又好奇沛城的祥瑞是什么样子，所以问问法曹。

Lizheng: Perhaps it's been recorded in the collections at the county archive.
里正：若说祥瑞，兴许往县志馆中能查到一二分。

Jiu Niangzi: Can I check them?
曲娘：那我能去看吗?

Lizheng: Citizens are prohibited from entering the archive. Along with the collections, the classified county annuals are preserved there.
里正：县志馆从不对外人开放。那处除了几柜藏书，还有本城历年来的各种大事记录。

Lizheng: Put your curiosity away, Jiǔ Niángzǐ; it's time for you to go back home now.
里正：你这好奇的心思只能暂且收一收了，曲娘。天色也不早，你快些回去吧。

With Lǐzhèng and Fǎcáo fading into the distance, Jiǔ Niángzǐ gives her bundle a shake, catches some sesame seeds in her hand, and starts chewing on them.
目送着里正和法曹走远了，曲娘抖落抖落包袱，把些芝麻碎屑落在手里，嚼起来。

Throughout the day, Jiǔ Niángzǐ encountered many individuals, but Fǎcáo's actions intrigued her more than anything else. It seems this prohibition is indeed as lax as Ms. Xǔ claimed. So why, she wonders, has it not yet been abolished?
这一日碰见了不少人，不过她最好奇的是法曹的作为。想来这禁酒令当真如老板娘所说，一点也不严，那为什么还不早早废止了呢?

6#1
6#1

去岁如山
Time Slipping Away CH16601-05

Months pass. The biting north wind heralds the coming of the Dùshuò Festival, together with liquor permit days, so the tavern has been buzzing with guests for several days.
不觉过了数月有余，连日朔风紧起，不近日便临近度朔节，因这节前后都算放酒日，酒坊里一连几天都是宾客满堂。

The front hall is warmed by a charcoal fire, creating a cozy and festive atmosphere.
前厅里簇了炭火，暖融融的，颇有节日气氛。

In recent days, the town's celebrated Storyteller has taken the stage once again, spending several days narrating tales in the tavern.
早些天，城里红人又摆开台面，连着好几日都在酒坊内说书。

Storyteller: It is said ...
说书先生：且说——

The Storyteller's voice booms throughout the room. His tales are so captivating that they seize the ears of all present. Within a few sentences, even the most avid drinkers forget to raise their cups to their lips.
说书的声音洪亮，口里的故事也精妙，像把众人的耳朵都抓住了，三两句下来，连贪杯的酒客都忘了往嘴里送酒。

Storyteller: It is said there is a place haunted by miasma in the south of the land. The miasma there shifts its form into many Yāos, and they attack people.
说书先生：且说岭南一块儿烟气弥漫，常有瘴气聚凝，化作妖物袭人。

Storyteller: Meanwhile, in the Central Plains, a monster originating from dryness dominates. Wherever it goes, drought follows, and people suffer famine.
说书先生：且说中原腹地有旱鬼横行，所到之处大旱，滴雨不下，寸草不生，百姓愁苦。

Storyteller: The rivers and lakes are overrun with huge snakes called Gōushé. They are more than 20 meters long with hooks on their tails, hooking people and cows into the water to eat them.
说书先生：沿江，湖地大泽间，有钩蛇，长七八丈，尾末有岐，蛇在山涧水中，以尾钩岸上人、牛食之。

Storyteller: To prevent these monsters from hurting people, Yāo hunters travel the world searching haunted places in order to expel them with their special power.
说书先生：故而便有云游的捉妖师，游历各处，探诡寻异，专门以法术除妖。

Storyteller: They are the sword against evil, protecting people with their lives.
说书先生：以身为剑，保佑一方居民百姓。

Jiu Niangzi: Are they ... Xiángruì?
曲娘：那是什么？是不是祥瑞?

Storyteller: Not at all. A Yāo hunter is not a Xiángruì.
说书先生：非也，这捉妖师是捉妖师，祥瑞是祥瑞，不可混淆。

Poet: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, one more bowl of Great Mister!
酒诗人：曲娘，来一碗郎官清！

Poet: Jiǔ Niángzǐ!
酒诗人：曲娘——！

She is completely engrossed in the Storyteller's narrative, remaining oblivious to her surroundings until Ms. Xǔ comes over and tugs her sleeve.
曲娘完全沉浸在说书先生的故事里，全然没听见，直到老板娘过来拉了她一下。

Ms. Xu: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, quickly, a guest is calling you.
许娘子：曲娘，别听了，快倒酒。

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, ok, one more bowl coming!
曲娘：哦，好、好，倒酒。

Ms. Xu: Forgive her; it's her first time listening to a professional Storyteller. She's been fascinated for the last few days.
许娘子：别见怪，曲娘是第一次听这说书，这几日都入迷了。

Poet: Don't worry, I understand. He tells stories much better than we do. It's no wonder she's so absorbed.
酒诗人：没事没事，这说书先生的故事从不重样儿，比起我们酒客间的几句陈年老谈资，可有趣多了。

Poet: It's too bad he only comes to the city during the Dùshuò Festival.
酒诗人：只可惜他总只在度朔节这几天来。

Ms. Xu: Speaking of which, it'll be a lot of work to decorate the tavern. Look at all these lanterns, candles, and ribbons!
许娘子：说起度朔节，你瞧瞧，我们坊里这几天也在忙着布置，又是买灯笼的，又是买烛火彩绸的。

Ms. Xu: Luckily, I have Jiǔ Niángzǐ to help me this year. What a busy year she's had. She ran errands, learned how to read, and delivered rice buns all around the city.
许娘子：幸好今年有个曲娘帮衬着我，细细数来，她这一年也做了不少活计，又是念书识字，又是送酒跑堂，还帮我给城里各处送饼子。

Ms. Xu: Though she still has a lot more to learn, she continues to impress me with her work ethic.
许娘子：虽然手上没那么利索，嘴上的口条儿也要学些，但腿脚快，都舍得花工夫，用跑的去做事。

At this moment, a guest enters the tavern. Seeing the joyous festival celebrations, he smiles and finds a seat.
此时，坊间来了一位客人，见众人欢欣庆祝佳节，也面露微笑，找个位子坐下。

Lizheng: One bowl of Great Mister, please.
里正：来一碗郎官清。

Ms. Xu: What a surprise it is to see you here, Lǐzhèng! Here, drinks are on me.
许娘子：难得里正来我酒坊里做客，这碗酒得我许娘子请你喝。

Ms. Xu: This is newly made. Have a try.
许娘子：新出的一缸郎官清，大人尝尝口味。

Lizheng: I don't usually drink, but we are in the countdown to the Dùshuò Festival, so I suppose I'll have a bowl or two. Besides, I have something I want to confirm with you.
里正：我平日里甚少饮酒，今日也是借岁除欢庆的由头，来你这里且坐一坐。不过也是有事要同你讲的。

Lizheng: Remember when we brought Jiǔ Niángzǐ here, you refused to take her in until we appointed you as supplier of the ceremonial liquor?
里正：还记得那会儿，你非要去了职祠送祝酒的活儿，否则就不收下曲娘。

Lizheng: Well, the festival is near now, and I finally have some time to come by. I want to ask: How are the preparations going?
里正：今度朔将近，岁除已至，这回得了闲，特意来问问，节上职祠的祝酒准备得如何了？

Ms. Xu: Already done. They're in the yard. Eight jars of liquor, all made with the best ingredients.
许娘子：老早就备好了，往年照例，全在我酒坊院中，一列八缸，都是醇香的上等好酒。

Ms. Xu: It was the request that I took most seriously all year! If anything goes wrong with them, people will lose their faith in me.
许娘子：这又是祝酒，又是用在节上的，我可不敢怠慢。要是有差错了，可不是砸了我酒坊的招牌。

Lǐzhèng nods in satisfaction, knowing that Ms. Xǔ has taken her role to heart.
听闻此言，知许娘子对此极上心，里正满意地点头。

Lizheng: Relax. I'm just asking. The Zhílǐ is the one checking all the ceremonial supplies.
里正：往年都是执礼来瞧过，验过。我今日来，也只是兴起一看。

Lizheng: Dùshuò is the biggest festival of the year. The merchant's hub will be packed with people during this time. I need to make sure everything goes smoothly.
里正：度朔节是沛城里最要紧的节日，这金市又是城中最大的坊市，我总要最后都过一遍，千万不能出差错。

Ms. Xu: Oh, for a second, I thought this was a full inspection. You almost had me panicking.
许娘子：里正也是个爱做个威武的虎脸吓死人的，我刚才差点被唬了一跳。

Ms. Xu: I was thinking, "Zhílǐ has already checked the liquor; why is he checking again? Have I done something wrong?"
许娘子：我心说，职祠和府里的人早就来看过祝酒了，怎么这会儿又来兴师问罪了。

Hearing their lively conversation, Old Drinker joins them.
见这儿说话其乐融融，旁边的酒客也来搭话。

Old Drinker: Lǐzhèng, I heard the festoon race is rerunning this year. Do you know when, exactly?
酒翁：听说今年要重启结社抢彩大会，是什么时候举行?

Old Drinker: You see, most of us don't know much about divination, ancient articles, or singing ... But racing is nice and simple. Whoever runs fastest wins.
酒翁：我们这些粗人，看不懂节日里的祭礼问卜，就这结社抢彩好看，热热闹闹地跑上一次，全城都凑着能瞧瞧。

Lizheng: It'll be around the end of the year, but it's not decided yet. Some items, such as the festoons and flagpoles, are all prepared.
里正：依旧是朔日那几天，执礼还在算吉日，不过五色彩绸、旗杆儿这些东西都已备下了。

Lizheng: I wonder who'll win this year.
里正：不知道今年头筹由谁家拿到。

Jiu Niangzi: Festoons, flagpoles, winner ...
曲娘：又是彩绸，又是旗杆，又是头筹，说了这么一大串东西。

Jiu Niangzi: What's the festoon race?
曲娘：所以，结社抢彩到底是个什么?

Ms. Xu: It's just a few layabouts running around, really ... It's only ...
许娘子：就是那些人闲着跑来跑去，就是——

Old Drinker chuckles and waves his hand, taking over the conversation.
一旁的老翁笑着摆摆手，接过话头。

Old Drinker: Let me explain. The festoon race is a racing event. Five flagpoles are set up at five locations in the city, each with multiple festoons of the same color.
酒翁：还是我沈阿翁来说吧，这结社抢彩就是在城里五个点，竖五支旗杆，每个旗杆上各一种颜色的彩绸子。

Old Drinker: There's no fixed route for the race. After it starts, the runners can collect five festoons in any order, as long as they finish with the red one.
酒翁：到了抢彩这天，报了名的人就都从一处出发，路线不规定，谁先拿到五条彩绸子谁就赢了，不过最后一条必是拿的红绸子才行。

Old Drinker: The first to get the red wins, and the Zhící will grant him a wish.
酒翁：那第一个拿到红绸子的，我们就叫“拔头筹”，此人可以让职祠给一个福愿来实现。

Jiu Niangzi: A wish ... Any wish?
曲娘：那……什么福愿都能实现吗?

Seeing Jiǔ Niángzǐ's enthusiasm, Lǐzhèng strokes his beard, a smile growing on his face.
里正闻言，用手捋着胡须，面上带笑。

Lizheng: Not if you're wishing for a star in the sky. Most people ask for some grains, clothes, or other daily necessities. Others ask for jade pendants, tea bricks, and the like.
里正：若是摘星要月的，便给不了。大部分人要的多是米粮、油布之类的，不过也有要别的东西的，比如玉佩、棋谱、茶砖之类的。

Lizheng: Nothing worth more than a few loads of rice.
里正：零零散散，上下总不过几担子米粮的价儿。

Jiu Niangzi: Can I wish to go to the county archive and read the books there?
曲娘：那让县志馆放我进去查书，行不行?

Lizheng: Well ... Probably, yes. If you win the race, that is.
里正：这……倘若曲娘真能拔得头筹，也未尝不可。

After a brief chat, Lǐzhèng takes his leave, and Ms. Xǔ hurries over to speak with Jiǔ Niángzǐ.
又闲聊片刻，待里正告辞出了门，许娘子才忙过来与曲娘说话。

Ms. Xu: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, are you serious about joining the festoon race?
许娘子：曲娘，你莫不是真要去参加结社抢彩大赛?

Ms. Xu: Every past winner has been a patroller! They're strong and, of course, know the city like the back of their hands.
许娘子：往年都是那些巡城郎拔得头筹的，他们整日在城里巡查，脚上力气足，对城里各处都熟悉。

Jiu Niangzi: I know the city well, too! I deliver buns all over the city all the time!
曲娘：我也很熟悉路，送了这么多糟饼子，早把路全认识了。

Jiu Niangzi: And I'm a fast runner! Much faster than before!
曲娘：而且我跑得很快，比原来还快了。

Ms. Xu: Well, you surely are ... But I'm worried you might get hurt during the race.
许娘子：这话倒是不假，只是那抢彩人多且杂，怕你磕碰到。

Ms. Xu: If something goes wrong, who'll take over the—
许娘子：你要是出了什么事，我这酒坊便后继——

Ms. Xu: See me in the yard tonight. I have something to tell you.
许娘子：晚上你且在院中等我，我有事同你说。

As night falls, the courtyard is stripped of its daytime clamor, leaving only the liquor jars standing against the wall. There is no sound but the gurgling of water—a babbling particularly pronounced in the stillness of the night.
入夜，院里没了白日的喧嚣，只有酒坛子靠墙而立。哗啦啦一阵水声传来，在夜里格外明显。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ, mimicking Ms. Xǔ, dips the liquor ladle into the vat, scooping out the lees to place in a wooden basin.
曲娘学着老板娘，将酒瓢探入酒缸，然后捞出酒糟放在木盆中。

By the time she reaches the kitchen, an oil lamp has already been lit on the table, with wheat flour piled beside it.
及至厨房，案上早已点上油灯，麦粉也堆在一旁。

Ms. Xu: The key is the ratio of ingredients.
许娘子：这做糟饼子的诀窍自然就是比例。

Ms. Xu: Four cups of Jiǔniàng and one cup of wheat flour. No water.
许娘子：两斤酒糟，八两麦子粉，不加一丁点儿水。

Ms. Xu: Before you mix them together, you need to squeeze the liquor out of it, so the bun will be chewy.
许娘子：酒糟要先用手把里面的酒挤出来，这样饼子面才劲道，烤出来的才香。

Ms. Xu: Always use newly ground wheat flour. Inspect the flour for any large particles; it should be as fine as rouge powder.
许娘子：麦子粉则要选当月新磨出来的，不能有粗粒，碾得要比胭脂粉还细。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ follows each step as Ms. Xǔ instructs her. She mixes the lees with the wheat flour and, using a special technique, patiently kneads them together.
就这样，老板娘说一句，曲娘跟着做一步。把酒糟与麦子粉混了，又按特定的手法，耐心地将它们揉在一起。

Initially, the lees do not integrate with the wheat flour, but as she works it with her palms, they start to merge together, giving rise to a faint fragrance—milder than the lees but richer than the flour.
起初，酒糟的颗粒还和麦粉有所疏离，但渐渐地，两者便融在一起，又生出一股淡淡的香味，比酒糟柔和，比麦粉厚重。

Jiu Niangzi: It's fun to make. The dough is soft and white. What's next?
曲娘：真有趣，软软的，白白的，接下来怎么做呢。

Jiu Niangzi: Flatten it and put it in the earthen oven?
曲娘：排成饼子，放进炉里烤?

Ms. Xu: Not quite. There's one last step. Stay calm, alright? There's no need to be afraid.
许娘子：不着急，还差一个东西，不过你要注意看，但别被吓到了。

Ms. Xǔ brings out a square wooden board and scatters a handful of wheat grain upon it. She then tilts a bowl of water, flicking her fingers to sprinkle water over the grain.
说罢，老板娘拿出一个四方四正的木板，抓了把麦粒撒在上面，又倒上一碗水，用手指沾了往麦粒上洒。

She mutters under her breath, and, in a matter of moments, the wheat grains begin to sprout open, growing upward as if devouring the air itself.
只见老板娘口里念念有词，三两下间，那麦粒便开口发芽，又吃风似地往上长去。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ watches the scene intently as the wheat sprouts on the table grow to the length of her palm before coming to a halt.
曲娘见此景奇异，只盯着看，那案上的麦苗长到一掌多高，才将将停下。

Jiu Niangzi: You—you know magic?
曲娘：你也会——老板娘你会法术?

Ms. Xu: It's my arcane skill, nothing special. I can hasten the growth of malt. Actually, there are many others in the city who can do much more.
许娘子：就是些神秘术，小戏法，这城里的很多人都会。我这却没什么厉害，只能催发豆子，只不过能省去我不少时间。

Ms. Xǔ slices the freshly sprouted malt, chops it finely, and blends it into the well-kneaded dough.
老板娘把刚长出的麦芽切了，细细剁碎，和揉好的面团混在一起。

Ms. Xu: This is the secret to our rice buns. The malt. It takes days for it to grow naturally, but my skill saves a lot of time.
许娘子：我们家这糟饼子好吃的诀窍，就在这多加的麦芽上。如果平时要自己发，这麦芽要几天才能发好。

Ms. Xu: Have you had malt before?
许娘子：你吃过麦芽吗，曲娘?

Jiu Niangzi: No, but I know it can be made into candy.
曲娘：没有，不过听说，麦芽可以做甜丝丝的糖。

Ms. Xu: It can make liquor, too. My father was the one who brought the recipe for ale to the city.
许娘子：不光能做糖呢，还能做酒。沛城里做麦子酒的技巧，就是我阿爷从城外带来的。

Ms. Xu: He was a merchant traveling the world. After he met my mother, he decided to stay here and opened this tavern.
许娘子：他原先是游历四方的商客，后来结识了娘亲，便落在此处，开了酒坊。

Ms. Xu: When I was a little girl, my mother always said that, thanks to my arcane skill, we could make liquor faster than any other tavern.
许娘子：小时候，我娘亲总夸我的小戏法，让我们家比别人家都省工期。

Ms. Xu: And my father told me stories of his travels. Today, what the Storyteller said about ...
许娘子：阿爷则给我讲他游历胡城汉地时，所见所闻……今日我听见说书先生的话……

Ms. Xǔ's voice grows fainter, her mind drifting off, as though she were recalling some past event.
许娘子的声音越来越小，似乎是想起了什么往事。

Ms. Xu: My yearning to travel the world gets stronger day by day, yet here I am, still at this tavern ...
许娘子：我一直想学着阿爷，去周游四海，遍历各处，不过如今又在沛城兜转这么些年岁。

Ms. Xu: There's always something that stops me from getting out of the city, or even out the front gate, for that matter.
许娘子：总有许多事绊着，让人迈不开腿，走出那一道土城门。

Jiu Niangzi: Ms. Xǔ ...
曲娘：老板娘……

Jiu Niangzi: Are you also trapped here?
曲娘：你也被困在这里了吗?

Ms. Xǔ's gaze falls upon the flickering candlelight. The shadows of the room seem to have taken the shape of things from long ago. She simply shakes her head.
许娘子望着闪动的烛火，那影影绰绰间，似是浮现了许多熟悉的事物。她只是摇摇头。

Ms. Xǔ looks at Jiǔ Niángzǐ and sees a reflection of her younger self. Suddenly, she feels a weariness enveloping her.
她回想起这些年的生活，看着曲娘，又仿若看见儿时的自己。她忽感周身疲惫。

Ms. Xu: Forget it. Go to sleep, Jiǔ Niángzǐ. Go to sleep.
许娘子：不说了，曲娘，先去睡吧，睡吧。

After returning to her room, Jiǔ Niángzǐ's thoughts linger on Ms. Xǔ. It seems the people of Pèi City all have their individual worries, be it Lǐzhèng, Ms. Xǔ, or the patrons.
曲娘回到屋里时，还在记挂着老板娘，沛城的人都有心事，不管是里正、老板娘，还是那些酒客们。

A familiar rustling emanates from the corners of the room, starting as a soft whisper and gradually swelling into song as the wooden dolls once again appear atop her bed.
屋子里传出熟悉的淅索声响，起先是比虫鸣还小的话语，后面渐渐变为歌声，那些木头小人儿又出现在床铺上。

Wooden Dolls: Make buns, make buns!
木头小人群：做饼，做饼！

Wooden Dolls: Rice buns! Grow malt!
木头小人群：糟饼子——发麦芽——

A wooden doll climbs up Jiǔ Niángzǐ's sleeve.
一个木头小人爬上曲娘的袖子。

Wooden Dolls: You have, personal feelings.
木头小人：私情，你动了。

Wooden Dolls: You treat her as family. You will never be a Xiángruì.
木头小人：把她当作亲人，成不了祥瑞。

Jiu Niangzi: Hey, stop! Shut up!
曲娘：唉，你真讨厌，快闭上嘴。

Jiu Niangzi: I don't have any personal feelings, okay?! So just stop talking!
曲娘：我根本没动私情，这都是你们在乱猜。

Wooden Dolls: Can't be a Xiángruì! Can't go out of the city! Forever and ever.
木头小人：成不了祥瑞，一辈子留在这里。

Jiu Niangzi: I won't stay here forever ... I won't!
曲娘：我不会一直留在这里的……不会。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ turns her back, doing her best to ignore the encroaching chaos, yet her heart remains plunged into turmoil.
曲娘背过身去，不理会这些杂乱的声音，不过心底却乱如麻。

6#1
6#1

结新彩

Festoons CH16601-06

Ms. Xu: Let me see ... Everything's sorted. Not many customers today, so I can handle things on my own.
许娘子：我瞧瞧，东西都收拾好了，店里我一个人也忙得过来。

Ms. Xu: Why don't you wear something lighter?
许娘子：对了，衣服你不换一套轻便的去吗?

Jiu Niangzi: It's ok. I'm used to this. It's my delivery outfit.
曲娘：够了，平常送饼子就穿的这套，临时换了我还不习惯。

Jiu Niangzi: I'm a fast runner. My clothes won't slow me down.
曲娘：其实，只要跑得快，穿什么都一样。

Ms. Xu: Last night, I had your shoes resoled. Oh, and I put new insoles inside.
许娘子：我昨晚把你鞋子底下又纳了一层，内里子加了垫子。

Ms. Xu: Hopefully, they'll be more comfortable than before.
许娘子：也不知道你穿着还舒服不舒服。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ looks down and presses into the floor with the tip of her foot. She then paces back and forth a few times.
曲娘低头看去，用脚尖往地上点了点，又踏了几下。

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, that's why they feel so much softer today. They're much easier to walk on than before. Thank you, Ms. Xǔ.
曲娘：怪不得，今天走路很舒服，多谢老板娘。

Jiu Niangzi: They won't chafe when I'm running now.
曲娘：到时候，跑起来肯定不磨脚。

As the conversation unfolds, someone approaches from outside the tavern.
话正说着，从酒坊外走来一个人。

Poet: Hey, Ms. Xǔ, Jiǔ Niángzǐ. Are you going out?
酒诗人：诶，许娘子，还有曲娘，你们这是要出门了？

Poet: Today isn't a liquor ban day. I'd like a bowl of Earth Spring to get some inspiration for my poem.
酒诗人：这也不是闲酒日嘛，我刚想喝上一碗土窟春，开开作诗的思绪。

Ms. Xu: Sorry, not many people have come today due to the festoon race.
许娘子：今日都没几个人来，全去看结社抢彩大会了。

Ms. Xu: And Jiǔ Niángzǐ has signed up for the race. So I just decided to close up and go cheer her on.
许娘子：碰巧今年曲娘也参加了结社抢彩，我也索性关了门，跟着去看看。

Poet: Well, it is indeed the most lively day of the year. Everyone's gathered on the street.
酒诗人：也是，这城里最热闹的日子，大家都围在街上了。

Poet: But if you close your door, where can we drinkers go to kill time?
酒诗人：不过你把门关了，让我们这些不爱凑热闹的酒客去哪里待着呢？

Ms. Xu: Sorry, but it's not every day that I'll get to see Jiǔ Niángzǐ participate in a race.
许娘子：生意日日都能做，曲娘这抢彩可不能错过。

Poet: Alright. Then, I suppose, I'll take a look too.
酒诗人：罢了罢了，我也跟去瞧一瞧。

She locks the door, and they head out onto the street together.
于是几人锁了门，一处往街上去了。

On most days, only a handful of people can be found by the city gates, but today, the area is alive with townspeople.
平日里城门这儿都只有寥寥数人，不过今日却人头攒动。

This is the starting line of the festoon race. All manner of people are waiting at the line—from fruit vendors to the old nightwatchman. They are stretching and rubbing their hands together in anticipation, eager for the event to begin.
结社抢彩的出发点就定在此处，这会儿报了名的都到齐了，平日里不管是卖果子的小贩，还是打更的老翁，都摩拳擦掌，整装待发。

Lizheng: Hmm. There seem to be many more contestants than in previous years.
里正：细细看来，今年参赛的人较往年多了不少。

Lizheng: Presumably, a number of them are newcomers to the city.
里正：这城门内多了许多生面孔，想来有不少新进的后生也入了此赛。

Facao: Recent years have been kind, and life has been good. The citizens have had a plentiful harvest and very little disease.
法曹：百姓安居才有闲情出来耍乐，这两年风调雨顺，也没什么灾病。

Facao: Of course more of them are willing to join the race.
法曹：粮食收成足，城内各处都过得不错。

Lizheng: Food comes first for the people. Only a full stomach and warmth can make one wealthy. Even this tradition started as a ceremony to pray for a good harvest for the next year.
里正：民以食为天，温饱才得富足。这结社抢彩的传统，最初那会儿，便是为了祈祝来年的丰收而办的。

Lizheng: Since you're standing by my side, I assume you won't be joining the race this year?
里正：想来法曹今年不参加么？

Facao: I haven't done so for years. But I recommended a few members of the patrol team join.
法曹：便是以前，我也连着几年都不曾参加了，只是推荐巡城队里的几个后生跑一跑。

Facao: Oh, and I heard Jiǔ Niángzǐ from the tavern signed up.
法曹：对了，听说酒坊的曲娘也报名了结社抢彩大会。

Lizheng: Is that so? I thought she was joking. She truly is a brave girl.
里正：她当真参加了？我还以为是随口一提，看来曲娘也是有巾帼不让须眉之勇。

Ms. Xu: Excuse me! Make way!
许娘子：各位都让一让，让一让！

Ms. Xu: Sorry, excuse me! We have a contestant here!
许娘子：请借过一下，我们这位小娘子也是参加比赛的。

Passing by these robust men only serves to highlight her delicate stature.
站在这些孔武力足之士旁边，才更显出她的娇小。

With her agile frame, Jiǔ Niángzǐ weaves through the crowd.
虽然在这里显得格格不入，但曲娘还是凭借着灵活的身型插入其间。

Jiu Niangzi: So many people ...
曲娘：这里真挤，这么多人。

Jiu Niangzi: Please, excuse me! Let me through!
曲娘：我想过去……请让一让～让我过～

Jiǔ Niángzǐ becomes as nimble as a loach, threading her way forward, striving to swim to the fore.
曲娘像是化作了个灵活的泥鳅鱼，在其中穿插前进，奋力游至前方。

Jiu Niangzi: Finally here. So many people have joined the race ...
曲娘：终于到了，有这么多人……

Jiu Niangzi: Not sure I can win.
曲娘：要是这样，不知道能不能拔得头筹。

Jiu Niangzi: But if I want to become a Xiángruì, I have to try ...
曲娘：不过，为了成为祥瑞，怎么也要试一试……

As the starting time draws closer, everyone holds their breath in anticipation, waiting for the signal to start.
时刻已到，众人都屏息凝神，等待发号施令。

Amidst the throng of burly men in coarse brown clothes, a streak of green catches the eye.
只是在一众粗布褐衣的粗犷大汉之间，夹了一抹迅捷的青绿色。

Ms. Xu: Jiǔ! Run faster, run!
许娘子：曲娘，快些跑！别怕！

Poet: Hurry up, people! Let's get this race started!
酒诗人：勉哉，快哉！

With the blast of the starting signal, the participants bolt like runaway steeds.
随着一声响炮起，众人皆似脱缰宝马，生怕落了人后。

They go different ways. Some choose main roads, some choose alleys, and some through courtyards. Different speeds, different distances.
不过各自的方向都不相同，有走大道的，有走小巷的，还有走坊间院门的，脚力有快慢，路程也有远近。

Jiu Niangzi: I know every street in the city, and I run fast. I just need to find the best route ...
曲娘：城里的坊街我熟悉，脚上的速度也不差，只要选一条最合适的。

Jiu Niangzi: *panting*
曲娘：呼——呼——

Jiu Niangzi: Faster, run faster! There's nothing faster than a Lùshǔ.
曲娘：跑快点，脚上再快些，没有比鹿蜀更快的了。

Jiu Niangzi: The purple festoon is at the butcher's on West Street, the yellow one is near the tea room in South Alley ... So the Bǎodài Bridge is the fastest way through!
曲娘：紫绸子在西街的肉铺前，黄绸子是在南巷的茶坊边……那走宝袋桥那条路最近。

Should one gaze down upon Pèi City from above, one would spy several black spots rushing forward—each a former victor of the race. Blessed with swift feet and an intimate knowledge of the city's layout, these participants are leading the pack.
若是从高处俯瞰沛城，便能看见数个急行的黑点，都是往年参加结彩抢社的头筹，脚力又好，也熟悉城内布局。

In the time that it takes for an incense stick to burn, several participants are already clutching silk in their hands. They each hold a different color, grabbed from flagpoles in varying parts of the city, as each participant has taken their own route.
未出一炷香的功夫，几人手中都有了绸子，不过各人路线不同，拿到的颜色也不一样。

Jiu Niangzi: *panting*
曲娘：呼——呼——

Jiu Niangzi: Now I have the green one, too. For the blue one ... is North Street closer? No, I should go to Mr. Shěn's house.
曲娘：绿的到手了，蓝的要走北二街？不对，从那沈阿翁的门前过最快。

Jiu Niangzi: Come on, Jiǔ, hurry, hurry! If you win this, you're one step closer to becoming a Xiángruì.
曲娘：再快点，拿到头筹就能做成祥瑞的一份事，曲娘，要再快点。

Half an hour has passed, and by now, everyone has moved to the main street intersection.
时间已过去半个时辰，众人都已移步到正街口。

Here, a flagpole has been erected, atop which flutters a single red festoon. The victor's coveted prize.
这里早已竖起旗杆，一条红色的彩绸子正在杆子顶端，随风飘动，正是头筹。

Lizheng: Indeed, the red festoon should be hung on the main street. It looks more festive here.
里正：这最后一条红绸，还是要摆在正街上才足够喜庆。

Lizheng: I wonder who will win this year. Perhaps one of the Fǎcáo patrol team?
里正：今年不知是谁拔得头筹，想必，还是法曹队中的良兵吧？

Facao: You're very kind to say so. The patrollers know the city well, and all of them are well-trained. They can certainly run fast.
法曹：里正过奖，我手下的巡城兵只是对城中布局熟悉些，又每日在街上巡查，脚力也有所锻炼。

Facao: But who knows? The city is loaded with talented people.
法曹：但城中人才济济，未必没有能胜过他们的。

As they speak, a chorus of voices rises in the distance. Cheers and shouts swell like a tide, rolling down the street—a sure sign that the victor has emerged.
正说着，远处先是起了人声，喝彩与叫嚷仿若海潮，顺着街而来，定是头筹已至。

But it appears to be a petite figure in green that is drawing the crowd's attention. Before they can discern the details, the figure, swift as a gust of wind, is already upon them.
不过远远望去，似是个娇小的绿衣身影，众人还想端详，那身影劲风也似的，已至跟前。

Facao: Looks like the winner's arrived. And they've left the others in the dust.
法曹：看来今年的胜者已到了，把第二名甩得影儿也不见。

Facao: But I don't remember any of the patrollers wearing green today ...
法曹：不知是队里的哪个后生，我怎么没见过……

Facao: Wait, that's not a patroller.
法曹：等等——那不是巡城兵?

The figure lifts a foot, stepping firmly on the stone guardian by the road and leaps into the air, deftly plucking the red silk festoon from the flagpole.
那身影抬起一脚，踏中路边的石守门，随即跃至空中打个旋儿，轻巧地自旗上摘下红绸。

In an instant, cheers fill the air—this year's champion has been decided. The crowd swarms forward. Amidst them stands Jiǔ Niángzǐ, the silk festoon clutched in her hand.
霎时间，欢呼声鼎沸，今年的头筹已定，众人都围将上来。只见曲娘站在人群正中，将手里的绸子举起。

Ms. Xu: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, you did it! One, two, three ...
许娘子：曲娘，你真的全拿到了，这一条，两条，三条……

Ms. Xu: ... Five festoons in total! You got them all!
许娘子：整整五条彩绸子，一条不少，都是鲜亮的。

Eventually, the crowd splits to form a path. Lǐzhèng strides forth, his satisfaction with this unexpected outcome evident.
人群慢慢地分开一条路，里正大步踏来，显然他对这个意外之果颇为满意。

Following in his wake are five large sacks brimming with grain—the rightful reward for the triumphant winner.
跟在他身后的是五只装满粮谷的大布口袋，那是头筹应得的奖励。

Lizheng: As you all know, the five colored festoons represent the five kinds of grains. May the collection of the five festoons bring us a bountiful harvest for every year to come!
里正：不错，正是五条彩绸子。五色彩绸映五谷，一轮年岁照一轮。

Lǐzhèng turns around, spreading his arms wide as he proclaims loudly to the assembled crowd.
里正转过身，张开双手向众人大声宣布。

Lizheng: Citizens, the winner this year is ... Jiǔ Niángzǐ from the tavern!
里正：各位乡亲百姓，今年的结社抢彩，取得头筹的乃是金市的曲娘！

Lǐzhèng bows slightly and, following the tradition of years past, inquires about the victor's wish.
官府的代表人微微欠身，依照历年的传统，询问头筹获得者的福愿。

Lizheng: Tell me your wish, and I shall grant it. Anything within my power.
里正：你可以提任何心愿，只要是在本府可行的范围内。

Lǐzhèng's mind still echoes with Jiǔ Niángzǐ's inquiry that day, her heart set on visiting the county archive to delve into matters related to the Xiángruì.
里正脑海中，还记得那日曲娘所询所问，她一心想去县志馆查些祥瑞有关的东西。

If this is her wish, a mere word to the keeper of the county archive would suffice. Lǐzhèng contemplates this privately, internally commending Jiǔ Niángzǐ's thirst for knowledge.
如果是这个心愿，那和县志馆的看守说一声就行了，里正暗自规划，又感慨起曲娘的好学之心。

Jiu Niangzi: Then ...
曲娘：那……

Jiu Niangzi: My wish is ...
曲娘：我的心愿是……

Jiu Niangzi: I wish for the liquor ban to be lifted.
曲娘：我的心愿是——废止《禁酤酒诏》。

The once bustling street now lies under a spell of silence. Not even Fǎcáo utters a word. The liquor ban is something no one would dare bring up to the officials.
原先还热闹非凡的正街，此刻像是被人用法术噤了声，连法曹也一言不发。禁酒令是人人都知，人人都不谈的东西。

The circle of onlookers first fixes their gaze upon Jiǔ Niángzǐ, then turns their attention to Lǐzhèng.
一圈人先是看着曲娘，随后又用余光瞟向里正。

Ms. Xu: Oh dear, forgive her, Lǐzhèng. She must have run so fast that she lost her mind!
许娘子：啊呀，曲娘是跑昏了头了，嘴里说胡话，还请里正当耳旁风，听过便罢！

Ms. Xu: Jiǔ Niángzǐ! What are you talking about?! Just ask for a few loads of rice!
许娘子：曲娘！你乱说什么废止不废止的，紧着要几担子米就行了。

Unlike his usual prompt replies, Lǐzhèng takes some time to contemplate. Then, with a wave of his hand, he instructs Fǎcáo to hasten back to the government office.
里正不似平日里那般及时回应，只是若有所思，又摆摆手，吩咐法曹受命回官府里跑一趟。

Before long, Fǎcáo returns from the outer street, clutching a document in hand. It bears a red seal.
不消片刻，法曹便带着一封文书从外街赶回来。那封文书盖着红章。

Lǐzhèng slowly unfurls the document, reciting each word and each sentence with great deliberation.
里正将文书徐徐展开，一字一句地念诵。

Lizheng: The Regulations on Liquor Sale and Consumption were issued due to the many natural disasters and food shortages of previous years, which have persisted until recent times.
里正：沛城往年因天灾水难，民粮告急，故而颁布禁酒诏令，自此延续至今。

Lizheng: However, due to the positive turn in the weather and the abundance of crops of late and, upon hearing Jiǔ Niángzǐ's wish, which I'm sure represents the voice of many ...
里正：今时风调雨顺，粮食谷草皆有盈余。又遇曲娘发民声，诉粮酒之愿。故……

All heads crane forward, listening intently.
众人都翘首，仔细听着。

Lizheng: Henceforth, the liquor ban shall be lifted! Starting with the merchant hub, selling and drinking liquor will not be restricted. Other districts will follow suit in due time.
里正：故从即日起，金市可解除酒禁之令，往后饮酒聚乐，不受限令，仍依常式。其余各坊听令行事，想是亦会陆续开放。

With the speech concluded, the members of the crowd look at one another in stunned silence. After a long pause, whispers begin to ripple.
话已毕，众人皆相顾无言，等了好一阵儿，才有交头接耳议论之声。

The murmurs grow louder, gradually coalescing into cheers. The news travels from here to the end of the street and then throughout the entire city.
未几，议论之声愈发嘈乱，慢慢汇聚成欢呼，那消息从这里传至街尾，又传至全城。

Citizen I: Really?
观众 Ⅰ： 这是真的?

Citizen II: We can drink anytime we want?
观众 Ⅱ： 闲酒日也能喝酒了?

Citizen III: Jiǔ Niángzǐ! Jiǔ Niángzǐ!
观众 Ⅲ： 曲娘！曲娘！

The crowd celebrates uproariously, as if this were the main event of the festival. The movement of the crowd squeezes Fǎcáo and Lǐzhèng onto the steps at the street's edge. Both wear smiles, observing the jubilant citizens before them.
人群正欢闹庆祝，好像节日已经降临，法曹和里正被挤到街边的台阶上。两人面带笑，看着一方欢贺的百姓。

Facao: Sorry to ask, but I don't understand what happened just now. Had you discussed this with her earlier?
法曹： 这其中……有何关窍？难道两位有言在先，适才专设此局。

Lizheng: It's not like that. It's simply a coincidence.
里正： 并非如此。今日一切，皆是巧合而已。

Lizheng: The abolishment of the liquor regulations was already on the agenda. We had planned to put up signs after the Dùshuò Festival. Jiǔ Niángzǐ's impulsive wish just so happened to align with our goals.
里正： 禁酒令废止本就走在官府日程之上，各坊都打算节后再张贴告示，谁知曲娘凭着性子，倒直接在结社抢彩的赛上说出。

Lizheng: As the ancient saying goes, "there is no time like the present." Why not seize the moment and announce the news a little earlier than planned?
里正： 俗话说，择日不如撞日，既然时辰已至，我只是顺水推舟而已。

Facao: I see ...
法曹： 原来如此……

Facao: Still, it takes gumption to do so.
法曹： 顺势而为，亦需魄力。

From this day forward, the citizens of Pèi City can drink at any time.
那日起，沛城的百姓们可以在任何日子里饮酒了。

The taverns all over the city start to see better days.
各处酒坊的生意也日渐好起来。

6#1
6#1

行路难
Difficult Is the Way CH16601-07

On this day, the tavern is abuzz with extraordinary liveliness. Although the Dùshuò Festival has always been a day of celebration, the lifting of the liquor ban has made this year's festivities particularly jubilant.
是日，酒坊中热闹非凡，虽然度朔节原本就是佳节庆贺之日，但因为禁酒令的废止，今年比往年更胜。

The patrons have been gathered here for days on end, drinking and chatting merrily. The stock of pre-prepared liquor isn't enough to satiate them, and they have to tap into the reserves set aside long ago.
酒客们连着几日都聚在此处，饮酒聊天，好不快活，连早早预备下的酒水都不够了，只能临时开几缸之前预留的。

Ms. Xu: Take it easy, people! There are only so many orders I can handle!
许娘子：大家慢慢喝，这几日可把我忙得不行。

Ms. Xu: I thought I'd prepared enough liquor, but the festival isn't even close to over, and I'm almost completely out.
许娘子：节前我还说预备下的几缸酒够了，这才过一半就快见底了。

Poet: I was starting to think that the liquor ban would never be lifted. Even today, I had to pinch myself to confirm it wasn't a dream!
酒诗人：闲酒日喝酒，在过去真是想都不能想。若不是掐起手来会疼，我还以为是自己喝多了发梦呢。

Poet: And it's all thanks to Jiǔ Niángzǐ. Who knew that such a careless girl would speak out for the people?
酒诗人：也是多亏了这儿的曲娘，她看着行事粗粗大大，却有这份心思，帮我们一众酒蒙子在里正跟前发了心里话。

Poet: She's braver than I am, that's for sure.
酒诗人：比我这个诗人有胆气。

Jiu Niangzi: It was nothing. All I did was ask a question.
曲娘：别说了，我只是嘴巴动动问一下。

Jiu Niangzi: Ms. Xǔ is always working hard to prepare and deliver liquor to everyone in the city.
曲娘：平时老板娘为了给大家送酒，又忙又累。

Jiu Niangzi: So I thought, "What if there were no liquor ban? Then she wouldn't have to be so tired."
曲娘：我想着，不如直接取消禁酒令最好。

Old Drinker: Ah, she's starting to sound like Ms. Xǔ herself. Loving and caring—especially to us drinkers.
酒翁：原是跟着许娘子学来的。许娘子宽心待人，又处处为我们这些酒客考虑。

Old Drinker: She's learned from the best. Ms. Xǔ has been a great role model for you.
酒翁：果然学礼学文，最后还学人最有用。有许娘子做榜样，果然是行不偏的。

Old Drinker: Come to think of it, Lǐzhèng made a wise decision in sending Jiǔ Niángzǐ to you. He knows your personality well.
酒翁：如此想来，里正那时把曲娘塞给许娘子，看来也是因其人品才有此行。

Ms. Xu: That's very sweet. Both Jiǔ Niángzǐ and I are flattered.
许娘子：沈阿翁好会说话，既夸了曲娘，又夸了我。

Old Drinker: It came from the heart. People my age never indulge in flattery.
酒翁：我这都是肺腑之言，我这个年纪，从不说阿谀奉承之语。

Old Drinker: Speaking of the liquor ban ... it has actually come and gone a few times in my life.
酒翁： 不过说起禁酒令……其实这禁酒令就是一阵一阵的，我老翁也是见过几次的。

Old Drinker: Over the years, the government has issued the ban during bad harvest years to stop people from making liquor from the grain.
酒翁： 粮食收成好的年份就没人管，粮食差的年份就怕你拿米粮去酿酒。

Poet: I suppose there will be no need for you to sell your famous rice buns anymore. Although I must admit, I'll miss the liquor made from them.
酒诗人： 以后就不用买糟饼子了，不过我还很喜欢喝那糟饼子泡出来的酒呢。

Poet: It's the perfect thickness and has that wonderful scent of roasted rice.
酒诗人： 酒味不浓不淡，夹杂着炉香和米的焦香。

Ms. Xu: Don't worry, I've taught Jiǔ Niángzǐ how to make the buns. We'll still make some now and then if there's a demand for it.
许娘子： 别急，做糟饼子的配方我已经交给曲娘了，偶尔还是能做个一两炉出来的。

Ms. Xu: They were more of a necessity under the liquor ban; I didn't expect people to like them so much.
许娘子： 那糟饼子本是禁酒令下，没得法子的法子，难得有人真爱喝。

Ms. Xu: But the tavern will continue to get busier, so I'm afraid we might not have time to make them anymore.
许娘子： 不过以后酒水要的量也多了，恐怕没什么时间做。

The crowd is all cheering and drinking. Ms. Xǔ pulls Jiǔ Niángzǐ to one side and hands her something.
众人皆把酒言欢，忙过一阵儿，许娘子把曲娘拉至一边，拿出一套东西交给曲娘。

Jiu Niangzi: This is ...?
曲娘： 这是……

Jiu Niangzi: The picture books of monsters and Yāos! Where did you get them?
曲娘： 这些书，全是山精野怪的画儿。老板娘你从哪里找来的?

Ms. Xu: Lǐzhèng sent these to you. He knows you're interested in Xiángruì and the like.
许娘子： 都是里正大人托人送来的，他知道你总喜欢问些祥瑞之类的。

Ms. Xu: Oh, and tomorrow is the first day of the new year. Let's go to the broken bridge together.
许娘子： 对了，明日便是朔日，听说前段时间，断桥那边有人见过巨鸟，可能就是你说的祥瑞。

Ms. Xu: Some say that a giant bird has been witnessed near the bridge; it could be the Xiángruì you're always talking about. And we can pray for good luck, as others do.
许娘子： 我们趁着这节日，一起去看看，顺便也跟城里人一样，祈福问卜一番。

Broken Bridge, Outside the City
城外断桥

No matter the weather, every year during the Dùshuò Festival, it always rains at the broken bridge outside the city.
说来奇怪，每年度朔节间，城外断桥这里总是下雨。

The scenery on the opposite bank is shrouded in fine rain. This atmosphere, as if intentionally breeding sentiments of grief, is sure to evoke memories of the departed.
对岸的景色笼罩在细细的雨中，此情此景似是有意凭生忧虑，让人记起故人。

Ms. Xǔ stands with an umbrella, surrounded by pedestrians seeking good fortune on the first day of the year. They hurry by, not pausing for a moment.
许娘子撑伞而立，周围有不少朔日走吉的行人，不过众人皆匆匆而行，一刻也不停留。

Jiu Niangzi: Hmm, I don't see a giant bird anywhere.
曲娘：真是的，找了一圈，哪里都不见巨鸟。

Jiu Niangzi: Is there really a Xiángruì?
曲娘：它真的会是祥瑞吗?

Jiǔ Niángzǐ tilts back her umbrella as she surveys the branches above, trying to imagine what the feathers and talons of a giant bird might look like.
曲娘撑着伞，在周围的树下转悠，一圈圈打量树上的枝叶。她想象巨鸟的羽毛和爪子会是如何。

Ms. Xu: It's really pouring down now. Maybe it decided to stay in the nest.
许娘子：可能雨太大了，它就不出来了。

Ms. Xu: Birds don't like rainy days.
许娘子：那些雀儿呀，鸟儿呀，是不怎么喜欢雨的。

Jiu Niangzi: What a waste of time ...
曲娘：原来如此，那我们不是白来一趟了。

Ms. Xu: A waste ...
许娘子：白来一趟……

Ms. Xu: If you have a question to ask and you find an answer, then I wouldn't say that your time's been wasted.
许娘子：有所问，有所答，就不算白来。

Ms. Xǔ leads Jiǔ Niángzǐ to the edge of the broken bridge. The remaining railings and planks have become especially bright in the rain, as if they had been broken by the flood only yesterday.
许娘子领着曲娘，走到断桥边，残存的栏杆和木板在雨水中变得格外鲜亮，像是昨日才被洪水冲断。

The silent passersby stop here, each holding a wooden slip in their hand.
不发一言的路人们在此停驻，大家手中执有木签。

Following suit, Ms. Xǔ takes out her own wooden slip and carefully inscribes the questions that have troubled her for many years.
许娘子拿出自己带的木签，学着其他人的样子，细细刻写下自己多年来的问题。

Ms. Xu: In the past, if you carved your questions on a wooden slip, the Gods of Shètí would answer.
许娘子：在以前每到朔日这天，在桥这边刻下问卜之辞，就会得到摄提神的回应。

Ms. Xu: Back then, I didn't take it that seriously, so I never asked. But when I did finally have a question, the bridge was broken, and it remained unanswered.
许娘子：我那时候还不信，等我想问什么时，桥已断，问卜的习俗也变为了无人应答。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ glances sideways and sees the words on Ms. Xǔ's wooden slip.
曲娘侧头看到了老板娘木签上的词。

Jiu Niangzi: "When ... my own journey ..."
曲娘：远方……未有期……

Jiu Niangzi: If no one answers, why do people keep asking?
曲娘：既然无人应答，为什么大家还要聚在这里，做这无用功?

Ms. Xu: Maybe it's because they already found their own answers. They just want divination to confirm it.
许娘子：是啊，或许大家心里其实都有答案吧，问卜的目的只是想要一个确定的回答。

Ms. Xu: So they can finally make up their minds.
许娘子：这样才能迈出最后一步。

Jiu Niangzi: If you want to do something, just do it. You don't have to think that hard about it.
曲娘：如果想做什么，就直接去做就行了，没有必要考虑那么多的。

Jiu Niangzi: Just like the person who left me at the gate of Pèi City didn't.
曲娘：就像我刚来沛城时，也是被人扔在城门口。

Ms. Xǔ gazes at the broken bridge, falling into a prolonged silence. The rain pitter-patters on her umbrella, on the wooden railings of the bridge, and within her heart.
许娘子望着断桥，长久地沉默，雨水淅沥沥落在伞上，落在断桥的木栏上，落在她心里。

She ponders for a long time, unsure of how to begin ...
她想了许久，不知如何开口，只是……

Ms. Xu: Jiǔ Niángzǐ ... I'm leaving here.
许娘子：曲娘，我要离开这里了。

Ms. Xu: Leave my tavern, leave Pèi City. Follow my father and travel around the world.
许娘子：离开酒坊，离开沛城，学着我阿爷的脚步，云游九州，遍历大千世界。

Ms. Xu: It'll be a long journey. I don't know when I'll be back, so ...
许娘子：此行想必会很久很久，我不知道什么时候还能回来。所以……

At first, Jiǔ Niángzǐ cannot make sense of these words. It is as if she has been transported back to that day when she tried to read the labels on the liquor jars.
起初，曲娘还没法组织起这些字词的意思，仿佛她第一天去学字时那样。

Hidden beneath her oil-paper umbrella, only the lower half of Ms Xǔ's face is visible. Her usual enthusiasm has been replaced by an almost indescribable, serene melancholy.
许娘子的脸恬静安详，掩在油伞下，只能瞧见下半张脸，那没有往日的热情，只有说不尽的忧郁。

Jiu Niangzi: ...
曲娘：……

Jiu Niangzi: I thought ... I thought you wouldn't leave. Not like the Daoist and my mom.
曲娘：我以为……我还以为你不会像道士，像我娘亲一样离开。

Ms. Xu: I'm sorry, Jiǔ Niángzǐ. It has always been my wish to see the greater world, to see what lies beyond Pèi City.
许娘子：对不起，曲娘，我一直想去更大的地方瞧瞧，看看沛城之外的地方。

Ms. Xu: In fact, every time the Storyteller speaks, I cling to every word. Every night I dream of the glorious scenery and legendary characters, and I see myself there, standing among them.
许娘子：其实，每回说书先生讲故事时，我也一字不落地听着。于是那各处的奇景和风俗人物，常出现在我梦里。

Ms. Xu: When I was a young girl like you, I told my father that I would become a merchant and travel the world ... I've been stuck in Pèi City for too long—so long that I almost forgot my childhood dream.
许娘子：小时候，我跟阿爷说自己也要做个走遍万里的商客，我在这里待得太久太久了，以至于我自己都忘了这份心愿。

Ms. Xu: The liquor ban was what kept me here. People needed me; they put their trust in me, so I thought it was my responsibility to run the tavern. But now, the ban has come to an end, and people can drink whenever they want.
许娘子：原先有禁酒令，酒客们都需要我，我没法从那份期盼与责任中脱身，如今那禁令已废止，大家可以去城里任何一处喝酒。

Ms. Xu: So I told myself, "This is your chance, Xǔ. It's time to do what you want—to widen your world."
许娘子：于是我便告诉自己，这或许是个契机。该去做我想做的事了，走出那城门。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ's carelessly drops her umbrella and steps onto the broken bridge, the rain cascading down her hair. Under the bridge, the turbulent waters rush by, their destination unknown.
听闻此言，曲娘兀自放下油伞，走上断桥，雨水顺着发丝流下，桥下的水湍流不止，不知奔向何方。

Jiu Niangzi: Fine. But I thought you wouldn't.
曲娘：好吧。我以为你不会像他们一样离开。

Jiu Niangzi: Since I've been here, I've been trying to find my mother—to recall what a Xiángruì is by piecing together scattered words from books and legends.
曲娘：从入城时，我就从那些散落的话语，从不同的画册里，试着拼凑起一个母亲，一个祥瑞。

Jiu Niangzi: I thought I'd figured it out—that you were the Xiángruì I'd been looking for. So I learned from you. I tried to become a good tavern owner. Even then, I was told I was on the wrong path. But I thought, "Why not keep it this way? Nothing bad has happened. Why not live my happily-ever-after with Ms. Xǔ?"
曲娘：我以为我找到了，学着成为它，但我越是模仿，却陷得越深。也许就这样一直保持现状也挺好，是不是?

Jiu Niangzi: But I was wrong. After all my efforts, you're still leaving me. Just like everyone else ...
曲娘：可我总也觉得不对。现在，连你也要离开了……

Ms. Xu: I'm sorry, Jiǔ Niángzǐ ...
许娘子：对不起，曲娘……

Jiu Niangzi: No, don't say sorry. Everyone has their own path. This is all because I followed the wrong one.
曲娘：不，不必言愧。每个人都有自己的路，一切都是因为我没走上该走的路。

The rain grows heavier. Jiǔ Niángzǐ trudges over to the broken edge of the bridge and puts her hand on the moist handrail. She gazes over to the other side.
雨越发地大了，曲娘走到桥面断裂的边缘，摸着湿漉漉的栏杆。对岸明明这么近，仿佛一抬脚就能走到，但却又那么远——

It seems so close, as if she could simply take a step to the other side, yet so distant, like the space she feels between herself and others.
She has never truly been close to anyone.
远得就像她和人之间的距离。她看不懂人。

Jiu Niangzi: The book Lǐzhèng gave me said that the wish, any wish, of a person who jumps to the other side of this broken bridge will come true.
曲娘：里正送的书，上面说，跃过断桥的人可以实现任何愿望。

Jiu Niangzi: If that were me, would I be able to jump over it ...?
曲娘：我想，以我的脚力能否一跃而过呢……

Ms. Xǔ swiftly steps forward and grasps Jiǔ Niángzǐ by the arm, afraid of what might come next.
许娘子见此，恐有闪失，忙上前几步，拉住曲娘。

Ms. Xu: No one's ever done that. Don't be silly.
许娘子：从没人能跳过去，别做傻事。

Ms. Xu: That's just a story, Jiǔ Niángzǐ.
许娘子：那都是书上的假话，曲娘。

Jiu Niangzi: I know it's just a story. But I took it seriously.
曲娘：是啊，都是假话。可我却当了真。

Ms. Xu: Jiǔ Niángzǐ ...
许娘子：曲娘……

Ms. Xu: Go back.
许娘子：回去吧。

The full moon hangs in the sky, illuminating the courtyard. All is still. Jiǔ Niángzǐ sits in front of a small table, a jar of fine liquor placed atop it, drinking alone.
月色挂满天，把院中照得透亮，一切都静悄悄的。曲娘坐在院中，摆了张小桌，并一坛美酒独饮。

Lifting her gaze, she sees that Ms. Xǔ's room is pitch-black. The mistress of the room has already gone to bed.
抬眼望去，许娘子的屋子黑乎乎的，屋子的主人已睡下。

Jiu Niangzi: Back then, I used to wonder why people liked drinking liquor ...
曲娘：唔，我原来还好奇，这城里的人为什么喜欢喝酒。

Jiu Niangzi: It burns the throat and irritates the nose; it's not as clear as water and not as warming as tea.
曲娘：又辣又冲鼻子，论清冽比不过井水，论芳香比不过茶汤。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ shakes her head, then lifts her liquor bowl to examine it closely. The bright reflection of the moon in her bowl resembles a jade plate or a delicate silver coin, shimmering and breaking with the movement of the liquor.
曲娘摇摇头，又端起酒碗端详，那时，一轮明月落在碗中，仿若玉盘，又如轻巧的银子片，晃一晃就碎了。

The little wooden dolls, timely as ever, clamber onto the table. They joke and giggle, adding a lively spirit to the previously peaceful courtyard.
小家伙们又恰到时机地爬上小桌，嘻嘻哈哈闹个不停，给冷清的小院儿增添了些活泛气息。

Wooden Dolls: Alone! Alone! All alone!
木头小人群：冷清——冷清——无人陪——

Jiu Niangzi: They said liquor could take all your worries away ...
曲娘：他们说，一碗美酒解千愁……

Jiu Niangzi: I didn't understand then, but now I do.
曲娘：我原还不懂，可今时今日，果然如此。

Jiu Niangzi: Alright, alright! Have a drink if you want.
曲娘：罢了，罢了，你们也喝一碗吧。

Wooden Dolls: Want some! Want some!
木头小人群：喝酒——喝酒——

Jiǔ Niángzǐ's eyes twinkle with joy as she brings forth a large bowl brimming with fine liquor.
曲娘眉目带笑，又拿出一只海碗，斟满美酒。

The wooden dolls commence a dance on the table, then, one by one, they leap into the liquor bowl, bobbing up and down within it.
木头人们在桌上跳起舞，接着一只只跳进酒碗中，沉浮上下。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ lifts her bowl and takes a sip. Then, mimicking the patrons of the tavern, she starts humming an often-sung tune.
曲娘端起自己的碗喝一口，又学着酒坊里的客人，慢哼起他们常哼的歌儿。

Jiu Niangzi: By the flowers in the snow ...
曲娘：两岸山花——似雪开——

Jiu Niangzi: Raise a toast, and don't say no.
曲娘：家家春酒——满银杯——

Wooden Dolls: By the flowers in the snow, raise a toast, and don't say no!
木头小人群： 两岸山花——似雪开——家家春酒——满银杯——

Wooden Dolls: You are having personal feelings now.
木头小人： 动了私情，就是这样。

Jiu Niangzi: I'm not! I never have!
... I guess the Daoist was right. I need to become a Xiángruì, or I'll never leave Pèi City.
曲娘： 我没有！我从没动过私情。看来，道士的话就是唯一正确的路：成为祥瑞，离开沛城。

Jiu Niangzi: Yes, that's what I should do. To be a Xiángruì is to ...
曲娘： 对，成为祥瑞，祥瑞就是……

Jiu Niangzi: To help people fulfill their wishes.
曲娘： 祥瑞是排忧解难，实现大家的心愿。

The famed tavern keeper of Pèi City, Ms. Xǔ, solemnly declares her intent to close the tavern and set off on a journey around the world. Her patrons are unanimously overcome with a wave of lamentation.
沛城里有名的酒坊老板娘，许娘子，最近对外声明要关了酒坊，出去游历一番。众酒客听了无不感慨痛惜。

Through several days of farewell toasts, each patron of the tavern says their heartfelt goodbyes to Ms. Xǔ.
在连着喝了几日的欢送酒后，众人才依依不舍，与许娘子告别。

On the final day, the patrons of the city all come to bid her farewell, except for Jiǔ Niángzǐ, the serving girl, who is rumored to have already found employment elsewhere. Shortly thereafter, the tavern changes hands.
那一日，城里的酒客都来送行，除了跑堂的那个曲娘，听说她早已换去了别家上工。不多日，酒坊也顺势盘给了别人。

6#1
6#1

且尽余杯
Till the Last Drop CH16601-08

Time flies, and more than a year has passed.
白驹过隙，日月如梭，转眼过去一年有余。

Pèi City seems to have not changed at all, yet everything feels different. The bustling merchant hub is still teeming with people—an endless stream of townsfolk traveling back and forth.
沛城似乎一点没变，又似乎什么都变了。金市街上依旧人头攒动，来往百姓不绝。

Poet: Mr. Shěn, it's been a while. You seem to be in good spirits.
酒诗人： 沈阿翁，有些日子没见了。瞧你精神头很不错嘛。

Poet: Would you care to have a drink?
酒诗人： 今日还喝酒去吗?

Old Drinker: The tavern on East Street has some new arrivals.
酒翁： 走吧，东街的酒坊酿了新酒。

Old Drinker: It's festival time now. Why don't we get together with some old friends?
酒翁： 正好趁此节日由头，我们聚一聚。

Old Drinker: Theirs isn't as good as Ms. Xǔ's liquor, but it's good enough and has its own flavor, I suppose.
酒翁： 虽然比不过往日许娘子家的，但也有一番自己的风味。

Poet: *sighs* It's so far from here. I miss Ms. Xǔ's tavern. It was closer, and the liquor tasted better.
酒诗人： 唉，又要走上那么一脚才能喝上喽，原先这许娘子的酒坊又近又好喝。

Poet: Now it's been taken over by someone, and the liquor tastes awful.
酒诗人： 如今换了人，连味道都全变了。只得舍近求远。

Old Drinker shakes his head and sighs.
老翁闻言，也连连摇头叹息。

Old Drinker: We average folk may not drink the finest of liquor, but we're certainly able to discern a good liquor.
酒翁： 我们这一介百姓喝的绝非佳酿美酒，但酒的标准，全都在我们嘴里。

Old Drinker: After one sip, we can tell when the liquor is brewed carefully and when it isn't.
酒翁： 谁用心酿酒，谁对付了事，一进喉咙，全都一清二楚。

Old Drinker: It's such a pity that Ms. Xǔ has left the city, and there's been no news of her return since. I fear I'll never get to taste the liquor as fine as hers again.
酒翁： 可惜了，许娘子云游四地去了，也没个回来的信儿。以后再喝不到那么好的郎官清了。

Poet: Heh heh, personally, I miss the liquor made of rice buns more.
酒诗人： 呵呵，我与阿翁不同，比起郎官清，我更想着那口糟饼子泡的酒。

Poet: Since the lifting of the liquor ban, there are more taverns than ever in the city, but not one of them knows how to make those buns.
酒诗人： 禁酒令解了后，城内酒坊虽慢慢多起来，但竟没一家会做那饼子。

Poet: Maybe the technique is lost forever, along with Ms. Xǔ.
酒诗人： 思来想去，或许那做糟饼子的手法就此失传了吧。

Old Drinker: Hmm ... I remember Ms. Xǔ mentioning that she taught it to Jiǔ Niángzǐ.
酒翁： 我记得，许娘子似是说过，她教曲娘做过糟饼子。

Poet: By the way, it seems no one has seen Jiǔ Niángzǐ for quite some time either.
酒诗人： 对了，曲娘……好像也许久没见到曲娘了。

Poet: It's all thanks to her that the liquor ban was lifted in the first place. It was she who allowed Ms. Xǔ to leave to fulfill her dream of being a merchant with no concerns.
酒诗人： 亏得她帮我们废了禁酒令，可禁酒令消了，许娘子也就没了牵挂，一路离了此地，学那胡商遍历四方去了。

Poet: Since that time, Jiǔ Niángzǐ's whereabouts have continued to be a mystery. Is she even still in Pèi City?
酒诗人： 也不知道曲娘在何处谋生，不知是不是还在沛城当中。

Old Drinker: Let it go, old friend. "Absence makes the heart grow fonder" and all that.
酒翁： 别想了，俗话说相聚有时，离别难舍。

Old Drinker: There will always be a bowl of liquor waiting for us drinkers to get together over. Let's cherish this moment, eh? Come on, let's drink.
酒翁： 不过还好，总还有一杯美酒等着我们这些酒蒙子，共饮此刻，走吧。

Poet: Go, go.
酒诗人： 走，走。

Poet: We better not keep it waiting. Let's go.
酒诗人： 美酒雅兴不等人，走吧，走吧～

As they walk and talk, they turn a corner, gradually making their way down the long street toward the east and disappearing into the distance.
两人边说边行，不一时已拐过街去，往东边的长街走远了。

A figure emerges from around the corner, she had been listening to the entire conversation.
转角处，一个身影慢慢走出，刚才一番对话全入了她的一双牙面儿似的耳。

Jiu Niangzi: ...
曲娘：……

The eavesdropper is none other than Jiǔ Niángzǐ. She has grown a touch taller than before and has shed some of her youthful naivety for a few strands of grace. Yet her every move remains as endearing as ever.
来人正是曲娘，许久未见，她比往日高了三两分，脱了几股稚气，添了几股秀丽，但举手投足间依旧烂漫可爱。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ follows the familiar path to the tavern and spots a man, the current tavern owner, standing behind the counter. There is not a single patron in the deserted front hall.
话说曲娘依着往日熟悉的路线，一直走到酒坊。抬眼就瞧见一个老板模样的人守在柜台后，前厅门可罗雀，竟是一个酒客也没有的。

It is clear that those scenes of merriment are but a distant memory now. A thin layer of dust covers the tables and footrests, and cobwebs adorn the overhead beams. There is no trace of this tavern's former glory.
当日对酒欢歌的景色，如今已物是人非，颓势具现。只留薄灰落满桌踏脚边，蛛丝儿结满了朱梁，哪还有半分往昔模样。

Tavern Owner: Another day and still no customers. Should I just sell this place ...?
酒坊老板：又是一日无生意，这闲铺子还是——

Jiu Niangzi: Excuse me, sir, one bowl of Great Mister, please!
曲娘：老板，来一碗郎官清！

Jiu Niangzi: The newly made one. Scooped from the middle of the jar.
曲娘：要新酿的，打酒缸里中间层。

Tavern Owner: Of course. Come, take a seat.
酒坊老板：好的，好的，客人请坐。

Welcoming the tavern's first bit of business in over half a day, the tavern owner quickly taps a jar, pours a bowl of liquor, and brings it forth.
对于半日来的第一笔生意，老板不敢怠慢，赶忙开坛倒酒端上来。

A cloudy bowl of liquor with rice dregs floating within it is presented before her. Its color is dull, and the aroma is surprisingly faint.
一碗并不澄清的酒，内中混杂着碎米糟，颜色并不清亮，气味也淡得出奇。

Jiu Niangzi: Hmm, are you sure this is Great Mister?
曲娘：多奇怪，这是郎官清?

Jiu Niangzi: It doesn't smell like before.
曲娘：闻着和之前的可不太像。

Tavern Owner: The previous owner left. I brewed this using my secret formula. It tastes even better and has a lasting aftertaste.
酒坊老板：之前那家走了，这是我家用新法酿造的，口味更甚，回味悠长。

Tavern Owner: I can't pour the liquor back into the jar, so just have a taste first. You'll see.
酒坊老板：况且，酒水出了坛就没有倒回去的理儿，你且先喝喝看。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ hesitates for a moment, then lifts the bowl and drinks it all in one gulp.
见此曲娘犹豫片刻，还是端碗一饮而尽。

She immediately spits the liquor back out. The taste is so awful that it is not even worth drinking.
可旋即就又把口里的酒吐出来，最差的口感，连喝的价值都没有。

Jiu Niangzi: Ew, it's awful. You haven't fermented it nearly long enough, and the rice you used is stale.
曲娘：真难喝，太轻了，酿造时间一点儿不够，米用的还是陈米。

Jiu Niangzi: Worst of all, you didn't seal the jar after you first opened it, and the water in the air has affected the liquor.
曲娘：最重要的是，你开缸后盖子没封严，进去好多水汽。

Tavern Owner: Ah, you must be a professional taster. You're right, but this is our cheapest liquor. Our best liquor tastes totally different.
酒坊老板：小娘子的嘴好生刁钻，不过这只是我店里的下等酒，待我拿出一坛好的给你尝尝。

Tavern Owner: Try it. I guarantee you'll love it.
酒坊老板：你再喝一碗，便知道我这酒坊的好处了。

Jiu Niangzi: No need. I'm leaving.
曲娘：不用了，我要走了。

Jiu Niangzi: Ms. Xǔ brewed every jar with her heart, no matter how cheap it was.
曲娘：如果是之前的许娘子营业，就算最便宜的酒也会用心酿造。

Her gaze grows increasingly forlorn. Finding no reason to linger any longer, Jiǔ Niángzǐ pays for the liquor and gets up to leave.
她的眼神越发失落，此地已无留恋之缘由，给了酒钱，曲娘便起身离开。

As she makes her way to the door, she hears the tavern owner behind the counter let out a sigh of lamentation, followed by a murmured monologue.
往门口走时，听见柜台后的老板先是哀叹一声，又絮絮念叨。

Tavern Owner: *sighs* Everyone says I'm not as good an owner as the previous one, and business is just getting worse.
酒坊老板：唉，人人都说我这盘下的酒坊，经营得不如前家，这生意是一天不如一天。

Tavern Owner: I've been losing money for weeks. If something doesn't improve soon, I'll have to let someone else take over the tavern.
酒坊老板：日日都在亏本，这样再过一阵日子，我也考虑把店给转出去了。

Tavern Owner: Or maybe I should just leave this place as soon as possible.
酒坊老板：想来还是早些收拾收拾，变卖的变卖，准备着离开吧。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ stops in her tracks and, as if spellbound, promptly turns around.
听到这话，刚踏出门的曲娘像是被施了法术。她忽然定住，继而转过身来。

The girl's eyes are filled with distress and confusion as she mumbles.
这女孩满目皆是担忧与困惑，口中喃喃着。

Jiu Niangzi: Leave? Like, what Ms. Xǔ did? Of course, everyone will eventually leave to fulfill another wish ...
曲娘：离开……？就和……许娘子一样？也是，你们总是有心愿的。

Jiu Niangzi: And I will help them if that wish is something I can help with.
曲娘：对的，对的，成为祥瑞，就要为众人排忧解难。

Ignoring the man's astonishment, Jiǔ Niángzǐ heads straight behind the counter and, after rummaging around for a moment, pulls out an unopened jar of liquor from a hidden compartment beneath it.
于是曲娘不顾老板的惊异，径直往柜台后去了，翻找片刻，又从柜台下的夹层中翻出一坛未开封的酒。

Jiu Niangzi: Amazing! You're still here! This is the fine liquor that Ms. Xǔ hid here before she left. Come, let's have a taste of it.
曲娘：幸好，你还在这里！这是之前老板娘藏的美酒，来，我们喝了，就能找到酒坊之前的味道了。

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, I forgot. You're the owner of this jar now.
曲娘：说起来，这酒现在根本就已是你的了。

Tavern Owner: I am, but I had no idea that it was there! You must have worked here before, yes?
酒坊老板：没想到许娘子还藏了酒，看来你是原先在这里做过工的。

Tavern Owner: Go ahead. Without you, I would've had no clue that there was a jar of liquor there in the first place.
酒坊老板：没你找出这坛酒，我也想不到还有一坛美酒藏在脚边。

With an ease that comes from extensive practice, Jiǔ Niángzǐ breaks the clay seal, and a unique fragrance fills the room. For a moment, she can almost hear the clinking of cups and the cheerful din of patrons, as if the tavern were alive once more.
曲娘轻车熟路地解开泥封，一股奇香灌满整屋，恍惚间，曲娘仿佛又听到了觥筹交错，推杯换盏之声。

A sharp, splashing sound brings Jiǔ Niángzǐ back to reality. She looks down at the mouth of the liquor jar to see a few tiny wooden dolls swimming merrily in the brew.
一声清脆的落水声，让曲娘回过神来，低头去看酒坛口，只见酒坛中三两只小木头人正在佳酿中遨游。

Wooden Dolls: Fine liquor! Tastes great!
木头小人群：好酒——好酒——

Jiu Niangzi: Hey, how did you—
曲娘：你们怎么——

These mischievous wooden figures have chosen this precise moment to appear. Fortunately, the tavern owner is so enraptured by the fragrance of the liquor that he remains oblivious to the oddity before him.
这些捣蛋的木头人们，偏偏这时候……幸而，老板站在一边陶醉于酒香，并未发现眼皮子底下的异样。

Tavern Owner: This scent ... This is indeed one of Ms. Xǔ's creations.
酒坊老板：这香味……确实是许娘子酿的。

Tavern Owner: There's no way I could make liquor as fine as hers.
酒坊老板：我是怎么也做不出这个味道的佳酿。

Jiu Niangzi: I don't think I could, either. Ms. Xǔ always selected the best rice in the grain store herself.
曲娘：是啊，许娘子在酿酒时，都会亲自去选米。

Jiu Niangzi: And she strictly followed the fermentation process. Even if the liquor ran out and the patrons begged her for more, she wouldn't open a new jar even a day early.
曲娘：而且出酒的日子一天也不会提早，早一天出酒，味道就要少半分。

As Jiǔ Niángzǐ speaks, she blocks the man's view of the jar with her body and deftly lifts the wooden dolls out one by one, concealing them within her sleeves.
曲娘一边说，一边用身形挡住酒坛，将木头小人一个个从坛中拎出来，收进袖子中。

"One, two ..." she counts in her head, in silent astonishment. The last wooden doll, as if it has dissolved into the liquor itself, is nowhere to be found.
一、二。她默数着，心下惊诧。最后一个木头小人，似乎已是溶进了酒中一般，怎么也找不到了。

Tavern Owner: Well, it seems we were destined to meet this day.
酒坊老板：你我今日有缘，又有此美酒，那就喝一杯吧。

Tavern Owner: So that I can learn what good liquor is and so you can relive past memories. Come, let's drink it together.
酒坊老板：我是尝鲜，你是怀旧。

With this said, the tavern owner sets out two large bowls, and, after a gentle trickling of liquor, they are both filled to the brim and emitting a pleasant fragrance.
说罢便摆出两只海碗，随后，涓涓酒声入碗，两碗满当当的美酒，阵阵香气扑鼻。

Jiu Niangzi: Wait, this is the fine liquor made by Ms. Xǔ.
曲娘：等等，这是酒坊原来的好酒。

Jiu Niangzi: I should use my own bowl to drink it.
曲娘：我要去后面拿自己的碗来装酒。

Continuing her journey into the past, Jiǔ Niángzǐ heads into the back. Her former room remains unchanged, save for a few scattered items. After searching for a while, she retrieves the bowl Ms. Xǔ gifted her on that memorable day.
接着曲娘便往后面去。她原先住的屋还保持原样，只是摆了些杂物。曲娘找了一阵，拿到当日许娘子送她的碗。

She returns to the front hall, only to find the tavern suddenly devoid of any human presence.
便又往前厅来，可这一眨眼功夫，酒坊前厅却没有人影。

Jiu Niangzi: That's weird. Where did he go?
曲娘：奇怪，这酒坊不大不小，他人去哪里了?

Jiu Niangzi: The jar is still on the counter, but one bowl has been emptied.
曲娘：这桌上的酒坛还在，两碗酒空了一碗。

There is a rustling sound from behind the counter, and a striped horse timidly finds its way out into the open.
柜台后传来一阵声响，一只长了斑纹的马怯生生地走了出来。

Visibly anxious, the striped horse paces around the room, its hooves clopping rhythmically.
长了斑纹的马略显焦急，在室内不停打转，踏出声音。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ steps forward, caresses the horse's neck, and gently strokes its mane.
曲娘上前，挽住它的脖颈，便轻抚马鬃。

Jiu Niangzi: Where did you come from?
曲娘：你是从哪儿来的?

Jiu Niangzi: Hmm ... have I seen you somewhere before, striped horse? Did the owner just leave?
曲娘：我好像在哪里见过你，长斑纹的马。原先的老板是不是已经走了?

Jiu Niangzi: He did say that he wanted someone else to take over. If he has left, then I will be that someone.
曲娘：如果是的话，那我就帮他实现了愿望。

Jiu Niangzi: And in doing so, I'll help him fulfill his wish.
曲娘：这样真不错，他有愿望，我便帮他一把。

Jiu Niangzi: That's exactly what a Xiángruì should do for people.
曲娘：毕竟，祥瑞就是不断给予他人，成全他人的。

A figure pokes his head in the doorway.
一个身影从门口进来。

Citizen IV: Hello, miss, is the tavern still open?
城中居民 IV： 老板，这里还卖酒吗?

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, the tavern's not—
曲娘： 我不是老板，老板在——

Jiu Niangzi: ...
曲娘： ……

Jiu Niangzi: I just took over it. Brewing takes another two weeks.
曲娘： 哎呀，这酒坊我才刚盘下，新酿的酒要等上半个月才能上。

Jiu Niangzi: You can come by then.
曲娘： 你到时候再来。

Within a few days, the whole neighborhood has heard that the tavern owner has sold the tavern and returned to his hometown, and that the previous serving girl, Jiǔ Niángzǐ, has become the new owner.
几日后，临近的街坊听闻，那酒坊的老板把铺面转手了，回了老家。

The liquor she brews is indistinguishable from that of Ms. Xǔ's original creations, and in no time, the scattered patrons once again have a place to gather.
而酒坊曾经的跑堂曲娘，现在成了酒坊的新老板娘。她酿出的酒和当初许娘子酿制的分毫不差，一时间，散落各处的酒客们又有了去处。

The tavern is bustling all day long, almost identical to how it was before.
酒坊中整日都热热闹闹的，与往日几乎无差。

Poet: This is the authentic Great Mister. It's the best in the city!
酒诗人： 这郎官清还是此处最正宗，最有酒味。

Poet: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, two bowls more!
酒诗人： 曲娘，再给我来上两碗!

Jiu Niangzi: Coming, coming!
曲娘： 来了，来了～

Jiu Niangzi: Don't rush me! My hands are full!
曲娘： 别催我了，这里就我一个人，都要忙不过来了。

Old Drinker: Hahaha! Feels like the old days, when Ms. Xǔ worked here alone.
酒翁： 哈哈哈，想之前许娘子也总这样嚷嚷着。

Old Drinker: After you came, things finally got easier for her. And now you're the one running the tavern all by yourself.
酒翁： 后面曲娘来了才忙得来些，如今她走了，你又回了。

Old Drinker: I wonder if there will be another little lady to come help you, just as you helped Ms. Xǔ.
酒翁： 不知后面会不会又有个小娘子来，帮衬着我们的曲娘。

Poet: Don't forget to make rice buns when you're not so busy!
酒诗人： 到时候得了空，还请曲娘再做些糟饼子给我们这些老客解解馋。

Poet: By the way, where did that striped horse of yours go? The one that used to stay in the courtyard.
酒诗人： 对了，曲娘，你坊内院中那斑纹马哪儿去了?

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, the horse. I have no idea. It escaped days ago. If you see it, let me know.
曲娘： 那匹马呀，前几日没看住，不知道跑到哪里去了。你们要是看见了，可要跟我说一声。

Jiu Niangzi: But let's not worry about that for now. It's time for a drink!
曲娘： 不过现在，大伙儿还是别想这些了，好好喝一杯吧。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ, now the new owner of the tavern, weaves through the crowd, her eyes gleaming with joy. She skillfully attends to the guests, each cup of liquor making the crowd momentarily forget their worries.
酒坊新晋的老板娘穿梭在人群中，含目带笑，熟练地招待着客人们，杯杯美酒让众人暂时忘记忧虑。

Indeed, she follows the Daoist's words, to become a Xiángruì, to do what she should do.
是啊，依照着道士的话，去做祥瑞要做的事，去做曲娘唯一要做的事。

In Pèi City, there are many worries waiting to be dispelled and, naturally, many wishes to be fulfilled.
在这一方沛城中，自然还有许多人的忧虑等待排解，自然也有许多心愿要被完满。

On the night of the year's beginning, the main street of Pèi City is at its liveliest. Crowds throng the thoroughfare, the cries of vendors ring out, silks drape high over the streets, and piles of red pomegranates and walnuts rise in little towers on the market stalls ...
朔日入夜的沛城正街，大约最是热闹。人头攒动，摊贩吆喝声不绝于耳，绸缎悬街而过，红石榴和胡桃累成小塔……

6#2
6#2